

The Girl Who Made Ordinary Days Feel Like Sunlight ✨

DEDICATION PAGE

For Kiye,
Some people leave footprints in your life.
You left galaxies.
I hope one day you understand how loved you truly are. Not just for your beauty — though you are genuinely one of the prettiest girls I've ever known — but for your heart. For your kindness. For the way you make people feel wanted without even trying.
This book could never fully explain what you mean to me, but I hope it becomes proof that someone out there looks at you and sees sunlight in human form.
Happy 14th Birthday.
You deserve every soft and beautiful thing this world has to offer.
Love always,
Mimi 💕

Prologue

Some people are pretty.
And then there are girls like Kiye.
Girls whose beauty doesn't stop at their face.
It lives in the way they laugh with their whole heart.
In the way they make people feel included without even noticing.
In the softness of their voice when someone's upset.
In the way they somehow become a safe place without trying to.
Mimi used to think people only wrote poems about sunsets and oceans and stars.
Then she met Kiye.
And suddenly every beautiful thing in the world reminded her of a girl turning fourteen.

MAIN CHARACTERS ✨

- Kiye**
The type of girl people naturally gravitate toward. Beautiful in a way that doesn't feel intimidating — warm eyes, comforting laughter, gentle energy. She doesn't always realize how much people adore her.
- Mimi**
Sensitive, observant, creative. Loves deeply and remembers tiny details about everyone she cares about. Often struggles to say how she feels out loud.
- Aaliyah**
The "mum friend" of the group. Protective, hilarious, gives the best hugs.
- Naomi**
Elegant, wise beyond her years, inspiring without realizing it.
- Maja**
Chaotic in the best way. Loud laugh, emotional heart.

Mahia

Sweet, funny, affectionate. Always the first to defend her friends.

Chapter One

Fourteen Candles

The room smelled like vanilla frosting and melted candle wax.

Golden fairy lights hung lazily across the walls while music played softly in the background, blending together with laughter and conversations and the sound of people trying not to cry over birthday speeches.

Kiye sat in the middle of it all like she belonged there.

Like the entire universe had quietly decided she deserved softness.

Mimi watched from across the room, holding a folded letter so tightly the edges had started bending.

Because how were you supposed to fit an entire person into words?

How were you supposed to explain that someone had become part of your life so naturally that imagining days without them felt strange?

Kiye laughed at something someone said, and for a second everything else disappeared.

That was the thing about her.

She never even tried to shine.

She just did.

And everyone around her warmed because of it.

Mimi swallowed hard, blinking quickly before anyone noticed the tears forming in her eyes.

Fourteen.

Kiye was fourteen now.

Fourteen years of her laugh existing.

Fourteen years of her smile making people feel safe.

Fourteen years of someone this beautiful being alive at the same time as everyone else.

The candles flickered softly.

“Make a wish!” someone yelled.

But Mimi already knew hers.

It was simple.

To keep Kiye in her life for as long as the universe would allow.

Chapter Two

The Girl With The Warm Laugh 🌤️

Mimi didn’t notice the exact moment Kiye became important.

That was the strange thing about it.

There was no dramatic movie scene.

No life-changing speech.

No music playing in the background while the universe suddenly revealed: *this person is going to matter to you.*

It happened quietly.

Softly.

The way sunsets happen while nobody's paying attention.

At first, Kiye was just another girl in crowded hallways and noisy classrooms. Someone Mimi occasionally laughed with. Someone whose name slowly started appearing more and more in conversations, messages, and thoughts.

But then little things started sticking.

The sound of her laugh.

That was the first thing.

Not because it was loud — although sometimes it was — but because it sounded real. The kind of laugh that escaped before someone could stop it. The kind that made other people laugh too without even knowing why.

Mimi remembered hearing it from the other side of the classroom once and smiling automatically before she even realized who it belonged to.

And then there was the way Kiye listened.

Actually listened.

Not fake listening. Not the kind where people nod while waiting for their turn to speak. Kiye listened like every word mattered. Like people mattered.

That was rare.

Especially at fourteen.

Especially in a world where everyone was trying so hard to be seen that they forgot how to see each other.

But Kiye noticed things.

She noticed when someone got quieter than usual.

She noticed when smiles looked forced.

She noticed when Mimi pretended she was okay.

And somehow, without making a big deal about it, she'd always make space beside her.

That was how it started.

Not with grand gestures.

Just tiny moments stitched together until suddenly they became something impossible to remove.

—

One rainy afternoon, Mimi found herself sitting beside Kiye during lunch while everyone else argued loudly over something stupid.

"I'm actually so tired," Kiye groaned dramatically, dropping her head onto the table.

Mimi laughed. "You're always tired."

"Because being this beautiful is exhausting."

Mimi nearly choked on her drink laughing.

"There she goes," Maja sighed from across the table. "The ego returns."

Kiye sat up instantly, flipping her braids back dramatically. "You're just jealous."

And maybe it was silly.

Maybe it was just another random lunch break in another random school week.

But Mimi remembered it later that night.

Not because of the joke.

But because of how light everything had felt around Kiye.

How easy.

Some people carried heaviness everywhere they went.

Kiye carried warmth.

—

The first time Mimi saved a screenshot of their messages, she stared at herself afterward in embarrassment.

Because seriously?

Who screenshots normal conversations?

But the message had made her smile so much she didn't want to lose it.

Kiye:

You better not forget about me when you become famous btw.

Mimi:

Never. You're literally coming with me.

Kiye:

As you should honestly.

Mimi smiled at the screenshot again later that night under her blankets while her room sat dark except for fairy lights glowing softly near her mirror.

It was strange.

How quickly a person could become part of your everyday life.

How quickly hearing from them started feeling necessary.

—

Weeks passed.

Then months.

And slowly Kiye stopped feeling like "just a friend."

She became:

- the first person Mimi looked for in rooms
- the message she waited to see pop up
- the person random things reminded her of
- the comfort she didn't know she needed

One afternoon during class, Mimi looked over while Kiye was laughing quietly at something Naomi whispered.

Sunlight spilled through the windows, catching against her jewelry and making everything around her glow gold for a second.

And suddenly a thought crossed Mimi's mind so naturally it startled her.

She's genuinely one of the prettiest people I've ever met.

Not just pretty.

Beautiful.

In the terrifying way sunsets are beautiful.

In the way songs are beautiful when they hurt a little.

In the way memories become beautiful once you realize they won't last forever.

Kiye looked up suddenly.

"You're staring again," she whispered, grinning.

Mimi immediately looked away. "No I'm not."

"You literally are."

"Am not."

"You wanna be me so bad."

Mimi laughed so hard the teacher told them both to be quiet.

And even afterward, while trying to stop smiling, Mimi realized something important. Maybe the best friendships weren't the loud dramatic ones people wrote about online. Maybe they were this. Tiny moments. Warm laughs. Saved screenshots. Rainy lunch breaks. And slowly, quietly, realizing another human being had become part of your heart without asking permission first.

Chapter Three

Tiny Things Become Important 🌷

Nobody talks enough about the little things. People always think love — even friendship-love — arrives loudly. They think it's giant speeches and unforgettable moments and dramatic scenes that change everything forever. But Mimi was beginning to realize the scariest thing about caring deeply for someone was how ordinary it felt at first. Because one day someone is just a person. And then suddenly:

- their name becomes your favourite notification,
- you start memorizing the way they type,
- certain songs belong to them now,
- and tiny things nobody else would notice somehow become important to you.

That was what happened with Kiye. Tiny things became important.

—

Mimi noticed that Kiye always stole fries off other people's plates even when she had her own food. She noticed Kiye said "bro" dramatically whenever she was shocked. She noticed the way Kiye fixed her bracelets absentmindedly while thinking. The way she scrunched her nose when laughing too hard. The way she leaned against people she trusted without realizing it. And somehow all those tiny details began collecting inside Mimi like pressed flowers between book pages. Carefully kept. Quietly loved.

—

One Thursday afternoon, the group sat together on the floor of Aaliyah's room while music played softly from someone's phone. There were snack wrappers everywhere. Naomi was attempting to braid Mahia's hair. Maja kept interrupting every conversation with the dumbest jokes imaginable. And Kiye sat beside Mimi scrolling through songs. "This one's so us," Kiye said suddenly.

Mimi leaned closer automatically to listen.
Their shoulders brushed for barely a second.
Still, something soft bloomed in Mimi’s chest anyway.
The song started playing quietly.
Warm.
Dreamy.
Nostalgic somehow.

“This literally sounds like friendship,” Kiye whispered dramatically.
“No, seriously,” Naomi agreed. “Like main character friendship.”
Maja pointed at the ceiling emotionally. “This is the type of song that plays during the montage before the friendship breakup in movies.”
“WHY WOULD YOU SAY THAT?” Mahia yelled.

Everyone burst out laughing.
But Mimi secretly opened her notes app and typed the song name down immediately.
Because now it belonged to Kiye.
That happened a lot lately.
Songs becoming Kiye songs.
Places becoming Kiye places.
Memories becoming attached to her so tightly that imagining them separately felt impossible.

—
Later that night, Mimi sat cross-legged on her bed rereading old messages.
Not because she was sad.
Not because anything bad happened.
Just because somehow conversations with Kiye had become comforting to look at.
Like rereading pages from a favourite book.
She stopped at one message in particular.

Kiye:
You know I love you right?
Simple.
Casual.
Probably typed without overthinking.
But Mimi stared at it for a long time anyway.
Because Kiye said loving things so naturally.
Like affection wasn’t embarrassing.
Like caring loudly for people wasn’t something to hide.
And maybe that was part of what made her so beautiful.

—
At school the next day, Kiye walked into class complaining dramatically about being tired again.
“I’m actually dying,” she announced, dropping into the seat beside Mimi.
“You say this every morning.”

“Because every morning I’m suffering.”

“You survived though.”

“Barely.”

Mimi laughed quietly while opening her notebook.

And without thinking, Kiye leaned over and rested her head briefly against Mimi’s shoulder.

Just for a second.

Just naturally.

Like it was obvious she belonged there.

Mimi stopped breathing for approximately three business days.

Kiye didn’t even notice.

She just sat back up again and started talking about something random while Mimi stared forward pretending her heart hadn’t just exploded.

Tiny things.

That was the problem.

Tiny things became important so quickly.

—

There were moments Mimi wished she could freeze forever.

Not because they were perfect.

But because they were real.

Like:

- hearing Kiye laugh so hard she snorted,
- sitting together in comfortable silence,
- sharing earphones on walks home,
- random “you okay?” texts,
- arguing over songs,
- group chat chaos at midnight,
- looking around during ordinary moments and thinking:

I love these people so much it scares me a little.

Maybe growing up was just learning that happiness often looked small while you were inside it.

Maybe one day all of this would become nostalgia.

And maybe that was why Mimi kept memorizing everything.

Just in case.

—

That evening, while reorganizing photos on her phone, Mimi paused on a blurry picture of Kiye laughing.

It wasn’t even a good photo.

The lighting was bad.

Half her face was blurry from movement.

Maja’s hand was randomly visible in the corner.

But somehow it still felt beautiful.

Because happiness had existed inside that exact second.

Mimi smiled softly before saving it into a separate album titled:

“Important.”

And maybe that explained everything.

Kiye had quietly become important.

Not in one dramatic moment.

But through hundreds of tiny ones.

Chapter Four

“*You Awake?*” 🌙

There was something strangely intimate about late-night conversations.

Maybe it was because the world softened after midnight.

Everything became quieter then.

No crowded classrooms.

No loud hallways.

No pressure to look put together.

Just dim phone screens glowing in dark bedrooms while people admitted the kinds of things they were too distracted to say during the day.

Mimi loved nighttime for that reason.

And recently, Kiye had started becoming part of it.

—

At 12:47am, Mimi lay under her blankets staring at the ceiling while rain tapped softly against her window.

Her room glowed faintly from fairy lights near her mirror.

Homework sat unfinished on the floor.

A playlist played quietly through one earphone.

And despite being exhausted, she couldn’t sleep.

Her phone buzzed suddenly.

Kiye:

you awake?

Mimi smiled instantly.

There it was again.

That automatic happiness.

The kind that appeared before she could stop it.

Mimi:

obviously

Three dots appeared immediately.

Kiye:

i cant sleep bro

Mimi:

skill issue honestly

Kiye:

wow okay.

Kiye:

i thought this was a safe space

Mimi laughed quietly into her pillow.

Outside, rain continued falling steadily while the conversation stretched on the way it always seemed to with Kiye — naturally.

Effortlessly.

Like talking to her didn’t require thinking too hard.

—

They started with random things first.

Teachers they disliked.

Funny videos.

Songs.

Which snacks were objectively superior.

Then somehow, as midnight conversations often did, things drifted softer.

Kiye:

do you ever feel scared of growing up?

Mimi stared at the message for a second.

Mimi:

all the time honestly

A pause.

Then:

Kiye:

i dont wanna lose people

Something in Mimi’s chest tightened unexpectedly.

Because underneath Kiye’s jokes and dramatic personality and beautiful laugh, there were moments like this.

Moments where she sounded small.

Human.

Fourteen.

Mimi typed slowly this time.

Mimi:

you wont lose me

Seen.

Typing...

Stopped.

Typing again.

Kiye:

promise?

Mimi swallowed hard for some reason.

It was such a tiny question.

But suddenly it felt important.

Like one of those moments people accidentally remembered forever.

Mimi:

promise.

—

For a while neither of them texted.

But it wasn’t awkward.

That was another thing Mimi loved about Kiye.

Silence with her never felt empty.

The rain outside grew heavier.

Mimi could practically imagine Kiye in her own room somewhere:

- tangled in blankets,
- face lit by her phone screen,
- probably making dramatic facial expressions at messages no one else could see.

The thought made her smile.

Then another message appeared.

Kiye:

wait im being serious though

Kiye:

im really glad we became friends

Mimi’s heart physically hurt a little.

Not painfully.

Just... deeply.

Like someone pressing softly against a bruise.

Because Kiye probably had no idea what her words did to people.

No idea how naturally loved she was.

Mimi stared at the screen for almost a full minute before replying.

Mimi:

me too

Then after a pause:

Mimi:

more than you know actually

This time Kiye took longer to answer.

Finally:

Kiye:

stop before i cry rn 🥹

Mimi smiled into the darkness.

Too late for that.

—

By 2:13am, they’d somehow moved from emotional conversations back to complete nonsense.

Kiye was ranking biscuits dramatically.

Mimi was losing the argument on purpose because Kiye’s reactions were funny.

Voice notes started replacing texts.

At one point Kiye accidentally sent a voice note of herself laughing so hard she snorted midway through speaking.

Mimi replayed it three times.

Not because it was funny.

Okay, it *was* funny.

But mostly because hearing Kiye happy felt weirdly comforting.

Like proof the world still had good things in it.

—

Eventually, Kiye sent:

Kiye:

okay if i fall asleep mid conversation just know i love you

Mimi stared at the message.

Again.

Love you.

Kiye said it so easily.

Like affection wasn’t something embarrassing.

Like loving your friends loudly was natural.

Maybe it should’ve been.

Mimi typed carefully.

Mimi:

love you too idiot

A heart reaction appeared almost immediately.

And suddenly the room didn’t feel as lonely anymore.

—

The next morning at school, Kiye walked into class looking exhausted.

“This is your fault,” she announced dramatically, pointing at Mimi.

“How?”

“You kept me awake.”

“You texted me first.”

“Okay but still.”

Mimi laughed while Kiye dropped dramatically into the chair beside her.

Then quietly, so only Mimi could hear, Kiye mumbled:

“Worth it though.”

And for some reason that sentence stayed with Mimi the entire day.

Worth it though.

Maybe that was friendship.

Losing sleep because talking to someone mattered more.

Staying awake because another person’s presence made the night feel softer.

Finding someone who made 2am feel less lonely.

—

That night, before sleeping, Mimi opened their chat again.

Not to text.

Just to reread.

Her eyes stopped on one message specifically.

you wont lose me

Promise.

Mimi smiled softly before locking her phone.

Outside, the rain had finally stopped.

But somehow the warmth from that conversation still lingered anyway.

Chapter Five

The Start Of Something Soft ☁

Some friendships arrive loudly.

They burst into your life all at once — dramatic and obvious and impossible to ignore.

But Mimi and Kiye’s friendship didn’t happen like that.

It happened slowly.

Like a song getting stuck in your head after hearing it enough times.

Like sunlight moving across a bedroom floor so quietly you only notice once everything is warm.

—

At first, they were just people who talked sometimes.

Then they became people who looked for each other automatically.

In classrooms.

In hallways.

In crowded rooms full of noise.

It became unconscious.

Mimi would walk into school and instantly search for Kiye without meaning to.

And somehow Kiye always noticed first.

“There you are,” she’d say dramatically, like Mimi had disappeared for years instead of twelve hours.

Or:

“My favourite person has finally arrived.”

Or sometimes just:

“Bro guess what happened.”

Like continuing conversations with Mimi was the most natural thing in the world.

And maybe that was what made the friendship feel so soft.

Nothing about it was forced.

—

One afternoon, rain poured heavily outside while the group sat together in the library pretending to revise.

Pretending being the important word.

Naomi actually worked.

Everyone else absolutely did not.

Maja kept spinning pens dramatically between her fingers like she was in a movie.

Mahia was eating snacks she definitely snuck in secretly.

Aaliyah whispered answers every time someone got confused.

And Kiye?

Kiye sat beside Mimi doodling stars in the margins of her notebook instead of doing maths.

“You’re gonna fail,” Mimi whispered.

“I already accepted my fate.”

“That’s concerning.”

Kiye looked over suddenly.

“You’ll help me though.”

Not even a question.

Just certainty.

Mimi tried ignoring the tiny warmth that sentence caused in her chest.

“Maybe.”

“You love me too much to let me fail.”

Mimi laughed quietly. “You’re so dramatic.”

“And correct.”

Across the table, Naomi sighed without looking up from her work.

“You two are actually unbearable.”

“Thank you,” Kiye said proudly.

—

Tiny routines started forming after that.

Waiting for each other after class.

Walking slightly slower so nobody got left behind.

Sending each other photos whenever the sky looked pretty.

Kiye randomly texting:

this reminded me of you

And somehow those words always affected Mimi more than they should have.

Because being remembered by someone mattered.

Being noticed mattered.

—

One evening, the friend group stayed on call far later than they meant to.

The conversation moved from serious topics to complete nonsense every five minutes.

Someone started singing badly.

Someone else threatened violence.

Maja nearly exposed everyone’s embarrassing stories.

Normal behaviour.

Mimi lay across her bed listening quietly while laughter crackled through her headphones.

And somewhere between hearing Kiye laugh and Naomi yelling “MUTE YOUR MIC IF YOU’RE EATING,” Mimi realized something.

She hadn’t felt lonely in a while.

Not properly lonely.

Because lately, no matter how stressful life felt, there was always someone waiting on the other side of her phone screen.

Someone sending random messages.

Someone checking if she got home safely.

Someone remembering small details about her day.

Kiye had become part of that comfort without even trying.

—

The next morning, Mimi arrived at school exhausted.

Kiye noticed immediately.

“You look dead.”

“Thank you so much.”

“No seriously, are you okay?”

The question softened slightly at the end.

Real concern hidden underneath teasing.

Mimi shrugged. “Just tired.”

Kiye stared at her for another second like she didn’t fully believe that answer.

Then quietly, she slid a packet of sweets onto Mimi’s desk.

“Emergency happiness,” she whispered.

Mimi blinked.

“What?”

“You looked sad.”

Simple.

Casual.

Like caring for people was the easiest thing in the world.

And maybe for Kiye, it was.

Mimi looked down at the sweets for a second longer than necessary before smiling softly.

“You’re weird.”

Kiye grinned instantly. “But lovable.”

Unfortunately true.

—

That afternoon, while everyone walked home beneath a sky painted pale gold and pink, Mimi slowed slightly beside Kiye.

The others walked ahead arguing loudly about music again.

“You know something?” Kiye said suddenly.

“What?”

“You were kinda quiet before we became friends.”

Mimi looked over.

“What do you mean?”

“I dunno.” Kiye shrugged. “You smiled less.”

The words hit unexpectedly hard.

Because the scary thing was... Kiye was right.

Mimi hadn’t even realized it herself until now.

Kiye continued walking casually afterward like she hadn’t just said something that would stay in Mimi’s chest for weeks.

But Mimi kept thinking about it the whole way home.

You smiled less.

Maybe that was what good friendships did.

Maybe they returned parts of you that life had quietly taken away.

And maybe, somewhere between late-night conversations and shared laughter and tiny moments nobody else noticed, Mimi and Kiye had started becoming something important to each other.

Not loudly.

Not dramatically.

Just softly.

Chapter Six

Hallways & Glances 🏫

School hallways were strange places.

Too loud.

Too crowded.

Too full of people pretending not to care about things they secretly cared about deeply.

Every morning felt the same:

bags slipping off shoulders,

friends yelling across corridors,

teachers telling people to hurry to class,

someone always running late.

And yet lately, school had started feeling different to Mimi.

Not because the lessons changed.

Because Kiye was there.

—

“You walk so slow,” Kiye complained dramatically one morning.

“You walk like you’re being chased.”

“That’s because I have places to be.”

“You’re literally going to maths.”

Kiye gasped. “Don’t ruin my mysterious image.”

Mimi laughed quietly while fixing the strap of her bag.

The hallway buzzed around them loudly, but somehow conversations with Kiye always felt separate from everything else.

Like stepping into warmer lighting.

Ahead of them, Maja nearly crashed into Naomi while walking backwards dramatically.

“IF YOU FALL I’M LEAVING YOU THERE,” Naomi warned.

“You’d miss me too much.”

“That risk I’m willing to take.”

Aaliyah shook her head. “None of you are surviving adulthood.”

“Especially not Kiye,” Mahia added instantly.

“Wow,” Kiye whispered sadly. “Betrayal from every direction.”

Mimi smiled to herself watching them all argue.

Sometimes she wished she could pause moments like this.

Nothing important was even happening.

Just friends walking through crowded hallways together.

But somehow it still felt precious.

—

At lunch, the group crowded around their usual table near the windows.

Sunlight spilled across trays and water bottles while conversations overlapped messily.

Kiye sat beside Mimi stealing food off her plate without shame.

“You literally have your own chips.”

“Yours taste emotionally better.”

“That’s not a thing.”

“It is to me.”

Mimi rolled her eyes while hiding a smile.

Across the table, Naomi watched them knowingly.

“You two act like an old married couple.”

Kiye pointed dramatically. “See? Even Naomi sees our bond.”

“Our bond is you robbing me daily.”

“Love comes in many forms.”

Maja started fake crying immediately. “That’s beautiful.”

Aaliyah threw a napkin at her.

Everything dissolved into chaos after that.

Normal chaos.

Warm chaos.

The kind Mimi had started loving without realizing it.

—

Later during English, the classroom felt unbearably warm.

Rain tapped softly against the windows while students half-listened to the teacher explaining something about poetry.

Mimi tried focusing.

Really.

But it became difficult when Kiye kept passing her tiny folded notes every five minutes.

The first one said:

If i disappear tell everyone i fought bravely.

Mimi bit back laughter before writing:

You're losing a battle against Shakespeare.

Another note arrived instantly.

And losing badly.

Mimi shook her head smiling.

Then another note appeared.

You're pretty when you laugh btw.

Mimi froze.

Just slightly.

Her eyes lifted automatically toward Kiye.

Kiye sat there casually twirling her pen like she hadn't just altered Mimi's brain chemistry forever.

Then she looked over and grinned.

Mimi immediately looked back down at the note before her face could expose her.

Because what was she even supposed to do with that?

People didn't understand how dangerous compliments became when they came from someone important.

Especially from someone who looked at people like they truly meant it.

—

After class ended, everyone flooded noisily into the hallways again.

Kiye caught up beside Mimi instantly.

"You ignored my compliment."

"I didn't know how to respond."

"You could've said 'Kiye you're right and also extremely gorgeous and talented.'"

Mimi laughed. "Bit narcissistic."

"Only a little."

Their shoulders bumped together lightly while walking.

Tiny thing.

Again.

Tiny things becoming important.

Mimi hated how much she noticed all of them now.

The casual touches.

The glances during conversations.

The way Kiye always searched for her reaction first after saying something funny.

It was terrifying.

Not in a bad way.

Just in the way beautiful things often were.

—

By the end of the school day, everyone looked exhausted.

The sky outside had turned soft grey while students poured through gates in loud groups.

Kiye walked beside Mimi unusually quietly for once.

“You okay?” Mimi asked.

“Hm?”

“You’re calm. It’s unsettling.”

Kiye laughed softly.

Then after a second she admitted:

“I’m just tired today.”

Mimi looked over immediately.

And there it was again.

That feeling.

The automatic instinct to care.

“You should rest when you get home.”

“Yes mum.”

“I’m serious.”

Kiye smiled slightly at that.

“I know.”

For a moment neither of them spoke.

Just walked side by side while wind moved softly through the trees around them.

Then suddenly Kiye glanced over.

“You know I’m glad we’re friends right?”

The words arrived casually.

Like something simple.

But Mimi felt them everywhere anyway.

“Yeah,” she answered quietly.

“Me too.”

Kiye smiled.

And somehow that smile stayed with Mimi long after they walked separate ways home.

—

That night, Mimi stood brushing her teeth while replaying the day in her head.

Not the important parts.

The small ones.

Kiye stealing chips.

The note in English.

Walking home together quietly.

Hallways and glances and tiny moments nobody else would think twice about.

But Mimi did.

Because lately, every ordinary day with Kiye felt like something worth remembering forever.

Chapter Seven

Pretty Girls Never Notice 🌷

Pretty girls never notice they’re pretty.

At least not the genuinely beautiful ones.

The girls who don’t realize people look at them a little longer sometimes.

The girls who laugh freely because they aren’t thinking about how they appear while doing it.

The girls who don’t understand that their presence changes the atmosphere of rooms.

That was Kiye.

And honestly?

It drove Mimi insane.

—

“You need psychological help,” Naomi informed Mimi one afternoon.

Mimi looked up from her phone. “What did I even do?”

“You’re staring again.”

Across the cafeteria, Kiye stood arguing passionately with Maja over whether cereal counted as soup.

Which, first of all, was already ridiculous.

Second of all, Kiye was accidentally beautiful while doing it.

“How is cereal a soup?” Kiye demanded dramatically.

“IT HAS LIQUID,” Maja defended.

“That logic is concerning.”

“She’s right,” Mahia added.

Kiye turned immediately. “Mahia this is why I have trust issues.”

Everyone laughed.

Meanwhile Mimi sat there pretending her brain wasn’t currently occupied by the fact Kiye looked ridiculously pretty in natural lighting again.

Naomi watched her knowingly.

“You’re gone,” she whispered.

“I literally don’t know what you mean.”

“You look at her like she personally hung the stars.”

Mimi nearly choked on her drink.

“That is so dramatic.”

“And true.”

Unfortunately, it was.

—

The thing was, Kiye didn’t act like someone who knew how beautiful she was.

She’d complain about her hair one second while looking like something out of a coming-of-age film the next.

She’d randomly say:

“I look awful today.”

While simultaneously causing emotional damage to half the room just by existing.

It made no sense.

None.

One morning, Kiye arrived at school wearing oversized sleeves and sleepy eyes, complaining dramatically about being tired.

“I look insane,” she groaned.

Mimi stared at her.

Because somehow Kiye still looked soft and warm and effortlessly lovely.

Like the kind of person people wrote songs about accidentally.

“You literally don’t,” Mimi said.

Kiye squinted suspiciously. “Was that sincerity?”

“Don’t get used to it.”

Kiye gasped dramatically. “Guys, Mimi admitted I’m pretty.”

Aaliyah looked up from her phone. “That’s because you are.”

“Exactly,” Mahia agreed.

Kiye rolled her eyes instantly. “You’re all biased.”

“No,” Naomi said calmly. “You’re just genuinely gorgeous.”

Kiye physically hid her face inside her sleeves after that while everyone laughed.

And somehow the reaction itself made her even more adorable.

Mimi was suffering, honestly.

—

Later that day during art class, students worked quietly while music played softly from the teacher’s speakers.

Sunlight streamed through windows in pale gold strips.

Kiye sat across from Mimi sketching something badly.

“Why does your flower look depressed?” Mimi asked.

“It has emotional depth.”

“It looks like it pays taxes.”

Kiye laughed loudly enough that a few people turned around.

And there it was again.

That laugh.

Mimi genuinely thought she could recognize it anywhere.

Kiye pushed hair away from her face while still smiling, sunlight catching briefly against her jewelry.

And suddenly Mimi had one of those terrifying moments where she became too aware of how much she cared.

Because beauty wasn’t just appearance anymore.

Not really.

Beauty became:

- the way someone said your name,
- the way they remembered little things,
- the softness in their voice when asking if you were okay,
- the way their happiness affected yours.

And Kiye had all of that.

—

After school, the friend group stopped at a corner shop for snacks.

Maja and Mahia disappeared instantly searching for sweets.

Aaliyah argued with Naomi over drink choices.

Meanwhile Kiye stood beside the fridge doors staring dramatically.

“There are no good options.”

“There are literally hundreds of options.”

“None speak to me spiritually.”

Mimi laughed softly.

Kiye looked over suddenly.

“What?”

“Nothing.”

“You smiled at me.”

“You’re imagining things.”

“Hm.”

Kiye narrowed her eyes suspiciously but smiled anyway.

Then without warning she grabbed Mimi’s hand and pulled her toward another aisle.

“Come help me choose before I perish dramatically.”

Tiny thing.

Again.

Always the tiny things.

Kiye held people’s hands naturally.

Leaned close naturally.

Loved naturally.

But Mimi noticed every single time anyway.

—

That evening, while scrolling through photos, Mimi paused at one she’d taken accidentally earlier.

Kiye sat laughing mid-conversation, slightly blurry from movement.

Not posed.

Not perfect.

Still beautiful.

Actually, maybe because it wasn’t perfect.

Mimi stared quietly for a second before smiling to herself.

Then she opened the notes app on her phone and typed:

Pretty girls never notice they’re pretty.

Especially the ones whose beauty lives inside everything they do.

She reread the sentence once.

Then added:

Kiye is the kind of beautiful that makes ordinary days feel softer.

For a moment Mimi just looked at the words glowing softly against her screen.

And maybe one day she’d show Kiye these thoughts.

Maybe one day she’d explain all the little things she noticed.
But for now, it stayed safely hidden inside notes and glances and quiet moments nobody else understood.
A private kind of love.
The softest kind.

Chapter Eight

Screenshots Saved Forever 📱💥

Mimi started saving things without realizing it.
At first it was accidental.
A funny message here.
A blurry photo there.
A voice note too entertaining to lose.
But eventually her camera roll became full of tiny pieces of Kiye.
Not in a creepy way.
More like... in the way people keep souvenirs from places they love.

—
One Friday night, Mimi sat cross-legged on her bed while rain tapped softly against her window.
Homework remained abandoned beside her.
Instead, she scrolled through her favourites album smiling to herself.
Most of the photos made absolutely no sense out of context.
A blurry picture of Kiye laughing so hard she nearly fell sideways.
A screenshot of a ridiculous group chat argument about whether penguins had knees.
A random photo of snacks spread across Aaliyah’s floor during a sleepover.
Tiny things.
Ordinary things.
But somehow they felt important enough to keep forever.
Her phone buzzed suddenly.

Kiye:
bro i just remembered something horrifying
Mimi smiled immediately.

Mimi:
im scared already
A voice note arrived.
Mimi pressed play.

Kiye’s laughter filled the room instantly before she could even speak properly.
“WHY did Maja confidently say Paris was in Italy today? Like she said it with her WHOLE chest too—”
More laughter interrupted the sentence entirely.
Mimi physically laughed out loud listening.
Then the voice note ended with Kiye gasping dramatically:

“Actually nevermind maybe we should support women’s wrongs.”

Mimi replayed it twice.

Not because the story was *that* funny.

Mostly because hearing Kiye laugh somehow made difficult days feel smaller.

—

The group chat stayed active almost constantly now.

At any hour someone was always sending:

- random selfies,
- terrible memes,
- dramatic complaints,
- photos of pretty sunsets,
- or deeply unnecessary voice notes.

Especially Kiye.

Kiye treated the group chat like her personal stage.

One minute she’d be emotional:

guys i love you all actually

Then ten minutes later:

if any of you expose my embarrassing moments i will disappear forever

Maja immediately replied:

too late.

Chaos followed instantly.

Mimi smiled at her screen while reading through the messages.

There was something comforting about it.

Knowing people were there.

Knowing somewhere out there Kiye was probably laughing at her own messages before anyone even responded.

—

One afternoon after school, the group ended up sitting together at the park while the sky slowly turned gold around them.

Music played softly from someone’s phone.

Mahia lay dramatically across the bench claiming she was “too exhausted for existence.”

Naomi quietly braided Aaliyah’s hair.

Maja kept throwing leaves at people for no reason.

And Kiye?

Kiye sat beside Mimi taking random photos of everyone.

“Smile,” she demanded suddenly, pointing the camera directly at Mimi.

“No.”

“Coward.”

“You literally caught me off guard.”

“Exactly.”

Before Mimi could protest again, Kiye snapped the photo anyway.

“Delete that immediately.”

Kiye looked down at the picture.

Then paused.

“What?”

Kiye smiled softly.

“You look happy.”

The sentence landed strangely gently in Mimi’s chest.

Because lately... she was.

Happier, anyway.

Lighter.

And a lot of that had started around the same time Kiye did.

—

Later that night, Mimi received the photo anyway despite her protests.

She stared at it quietly.

It wasn’t perfect.

Her hair looked messy from wind.

She was mid-laugh.

The lighting wasn’t even good.

Still, Kiye had been right.

She looked happy.

At the bottom of the photo, Kiye had added text:

caught u smiling for once 🙄

Mimi smiled again automatically.

Then, without thinking too hard about it, she added the photo to her favourites album too.

—

There were certain memories Mimi already knew she’d miss one day.

Even while living inside them.

The park at sunset.

Late-night group calls.

Walking through school hallways together.

Kiye randomly grabbing her hand while talking.

Tiny moments.

But maybe growing up was just realizing tiny moments were actually the big ones all along.

—

At 1:03am, while everyone else slowly disappeared offline, Mimi remained awake scrolling through old messages again.

She stopped at one screenshot specifically.

It was simple.

Just a random conversation from weeks ago.

Kiye:

you know what i like about you?

Mimi:

what

Kiye:

you make people feel safe to be themselves

Mimi stared at the message quietly.

Because sometimes people said things casually that stayed in your chest forever.

She locked her phone slowly afterward, room illuminated only by fairy lights and soft darkness.

Then she thought something that scared her a little.

Maybe one day these screenshots would become memories.

Maybe years from now they'd look back at blurry photos and old messages wondering how time moved so quickly.

But for now?

For now they were still fourteen.

Still laughing.

Still loving each other loudly in all the small ordinary ways that mattered most.

And Mimi planned to remember every second of it.

Chapter Nine

Becoming Home

Mimi used to think “home” was a place.

Four walls.

A bedroom.

A familiar street.

Something physical.

But lately, she was beginning to understand that sometimes home could be a person too.

Sometimes it was the feeling that settled in your chest when someone answered your call.

The comfort of hearing a certain laugh after a bad day.

The quiet relief of knowing someone out there understood you.

And somehow, without Mimi noticing exactly when it happened, Kiye had started feeling like that.

Home.

—

It happened most on difficult days.

The kind where everything felt slightly heavier than usual.

One Tuesday afternoon, rain poured endlessly outside while students dragged themselves through lessons with exhausted expressions.

Mimi barely spoke all morning.

Not because anything specific happened.

Just one of those days where her thoughts felt too loud.

Kiye noticed by second period.

“You’re quiet.”

“I’m always quiet.”

“Not this kind.”

Mimi looked down at her notebook. “I’m fine.”

Kiye didn’t answer immediately.

Instead, she gently nudged her shoulder against Mimi’s.

Tiny thing.

But somehow it said:

I’m here anyway.

And strangely, that helped.

—

At lunch, the cafeteria felt overwhelming.

Too bright.

Too noisy.

Too full of conversations happening all at once.

Mimi sat silently picking at her food while everyone else talked around her.

Usually she’d join in.

Today she couldn’t find the energy.

Then suddenly a juice box appeared beside her tray.

Mimi blinked.

Kiye shrugged casually. “Emergency support beverage.”

Mimi laughed despite herself.

“There’s the smile,” Kiye said immediately.

Simple sentence.

But Mimi felt warmth spread through her chest anyway.

Because Kiye always noticed.

Always.

—

That afternoon during science, students worked in pairs while the classroom buzzed softly with conversation.

Kiye sat beside Mimi doodling random stars on the worksheet instead of answering questions properly.

“You’re failing this assignment,” Mimi whispered.

“And thriving emotionally.”

“That is not how science works.”

Kiye grinned.

Then after a second, quieter this time, she asked:

“You okay now?”

Mimi paused.

The easy answer would’ve been:

Yeah.

But something about Kiye made honesty feel safer.

“A little better.”

Kiye smiled softly at that.

“Good.”

No dramatic speech.

No pushing for details.

No making it into something huge.

Just caring gently.

And somehow that mattered more.

—

After school, the group stopped at the corner shop again.

Maja and Mahia immediately disappeared toward snacks.

Naomi complained about everyone’s terrible financial decisions.

Aaliyah tried unsuccessfully to keep the group organized.

Meanwhile Kiye stood beside Mimi near the drinks fridge.

“You know what your problem is?” Kiye said suddenly.

“I’m scared to ask.”

“You stay inside your own head too much.”

Mimi blinked slightly.

“That sounded weirdly wise.”

“I have layers.”

“Mostly chaos.”

“True.”

They both laughed quietly.

Then Kiye reached over absentmindedly fixing the sleeve of Mimi’s hoodie where it had folded awkwardly.

Tiny thing.

Again.

Always the tiny things.

But Mimi’s chest still tightened around the softness of it anyway.

—

Later that evening, Mimi sat by her bedroom window watching rain slide down the glass.

The world outside looked blurred and distant beneath streetlights.

Her phone buzzed.

Kiye:

did you get home safe?

Mimi smiled immediately.

Mimi:

yeah mum

Kiye:

as i should honestly

Then another message:

Kiye:

also u seemed sad earlier

Mimi stared at the screen for a second.

Mimi:

just tired i think

Seen.

Typing...

Kiye:

well if life gets annoying im fighting it for u

Mimi laughed softly under her breath.

Mimi:

thats slightly concerning

Kiye:

im serious.

And somehow, reading those two simple words beneath dim fairy lights, Mimi felt her chest ache again.

Because Kiye cared so naturally.

Like loving people was as automatic as breathing.

—

That night, long after the conversation ended, Mimi lay awake thinking about something terrifying.

Not terrifying in a bad way.

Just in the way deep feelings often were.

Because somewhere between shared laughter and late-night texts and tiny moments nobody else noticed...

Kiye had become part of her comfort.

Part of her routine.

Part of her happiness.

Part of the way she survived difficult days.

And maybe that was the scariest thing about caring deeply for someone.

One day they stopped feeling like “someone you know.”

And started feeling like home instead.

—

Before sleeping, Mimi opened her notes app again.

A habit now.

Then quietly typed:

Home isn’t always a place.

Sometimes it’s a person who notices when your smile disappears.

She stared at the sentence for a moment.

Then added one final line beneath it:

Kiye feels like coming home after a difficult day.

And somehow that felt both comforting and terrifying at the same time.

Chapter Ten

The Sound Of Her Laugh ☀️

There were some sounds people never forgot.

Certain songs.

Certain voices.

Rain against windows late at night.

And for Mimi, one of those sounds had quietly become Kiye’s laugh.

—

Friday mornings were always exhausting.

Everyone looked half-asleep walking through school gates, surviving purely on snacks and determination.

Mimi arrived tired already.

Not physically tired.

The heavier kind.

The kind that sat silently inside your chest and made everything feel harder than usual.

She barely noticed herself zoning out during registration until someone dramatically dropped into the seat beside her.

“There you are,” Kiye announced.

Mimi looked over weakly. “Hi.”

Kiye narrowed her eyes immediately.

“That was suspiciously sad.”

“I’m literally fine.”

“Liar.”

Mimi sighed quietly while looking down at her desk.

Usually she would’ve joked back.

Today she just couldn’t find the energy.

For a moment Kiye stayed unusually quiet too.

Then suddenly she pulled a folded piece of paper from her sleeve and slid it across the table dramatically.

Mimi blinked.

“What’s this?”

“Open it.”

Inside, written in rushed messy handwriting, were the words:

Congratulations!

You have won:

1 free emotional support conversation

+ a packet of sweets if necessary

Mimi stared at it for a second before laughing unexpectedly.

A real laugh.

Small.

But real.

Kiye immediately pointed at her proudly.

“There it is.”

And somehow that tiny moment almost made Mimi emotional.

Because Kiye always tried.

Always found ways to pull people gently back toward happiness without making them feel guilty for struggling in the first place.

—

At lunch, the group gathered outside near the field because the weather had finally turned warm again.

Students sat scattered across the grass while music played faintly from someone’s speaker nearby.

Maja lay dramatically across everyone’s bags claiming she was “too beautiful for education.”

Naomi told her to get up immediately.

Mahia nearly dropped her drink laughing.

Normal chaos.

Kiye sat beside Mimi cross-legged on the grass scrolling through songs.

Then suddenly:

“Oh my days WAIT.”

“What?” Mimi asked.

Kiye looked horrified.

“I just remembered the most embarrassing thing ever.”

Maja immediately sat up. “Tell us.”

“No.”

“Tell us RIGHT NOW.”

Kiye covered her face dramatically while everyone demanded answers.

Eventually, after several threats and excessive dramatics, she admitted:

“When I was younger I thought ‘idk’ meant ‘I don’t kiss.’”

There was one second of silence.

Then absolute chaos.

Maja physically collapsed sideways laughing.

Mahia screamed.

Even Naomi lost composure completely.

And Kiye?

Kiye laughed too.

Fully.

Uncontrollably.

Head thrown back beneath bright sunlight.

The sound hit Mimi instantly.

Warm.

Bright.

Alive.

The kind of laugh that made other people happier automatically.

And for a second, while everyone else continued shouting over each other, Mimi just sat there quietly listening to it. Because somehow the world always felt lighter when Kiye laughed like that.

—

Later during maths, the classroom dragged endlessly. Mimi stared blankly at equations she barely understood while tiredness settled back into her chest again. Sometimes emotions worked like that. They disappeared briefly before returning all at once. Kiye noticed immediately.

“You left us again.”

Mimi blinked. “What?”

“You zoned out.”

“Oh.”

Kiye studied her face carefully for a second. Then, very quietly so nobody else could hear: “You don’t always have to pretend you’re okay around me.” The words landed softly. Too softly.

Mimi swallowed hard while looking down at her notebook. Because maybe that was part of what made Kiye special. She didn’t force people to speak. She just made honesty feel safe. “I know,” Mimi whispered finally.

Kiye smiled slightly at that. Then she nudged her calculator across the desk. “Also I got the answer wrong three times so if we fail this assignment we fail together.” Mimi laughed again. And there it was.

That feeling. Like Kiye somehow kept finding ways to pull sunlight into difficult days.

—

After school, the sky glowed pale orange while everyone slowly walked home together. The conversation moved lazily between random topics: music, teachers, weekend plans, which fictional characters would survive horror movies. “Kiye would die first,” Naomi decided calmly. “WHAT?” “You investigate suspicious noises.”

“That’s because I’m brave.”

“That’s because you lack survival instincts,” Aaliyah corrected.

Everyone laughed.

Kiye looked personally betrayed.

Mimi smiled quietly watching the argument unfold.

Then suddenly Kiye glanced over at her.

And smiled too.

Not the loud dramatic smile she gave everyone else.

A softer one.

Like she was checking:

You okay now?

Mimi nodded slightly without thinking.

Kiye’s shoulders relaxed afterward.

Tiny thing.

But Mimi noticed.

She always noticed.

—

That evening, Mimi lay on her bedroom floor with headphones on while replaying one of Kiye’s old voice notes again.

The one where she laughed so hard halfway through talking that she couldn’t breathe properly afterward.

Mimi smiled to herself.

Then opened her notes app.

Another habit now.

She typed slowly:

I think some people heal others without even realizing it.

Then after a pause:

The sound of Kiye laughing makes difficult days feel survivable.

Mimi reread the sentence quietly beneath dim fairy lights.

And for the first time all day, the heaviness inside her chest felt slightly smaller again.

Chapter Eleven

The Language Of Best Friends

Every friendship had its own language.

Not actual words, necessarily.

More like tiny habits and understandings that slowly formed over time until two people could communicate entire emotions through one glance.

Mimi didn’t notice when it started happening with Kiye.

Only that one day it suddenly existed.

—

“You okay?”

The words came quietly from across the classroom.

Not loud enough for anyone else to hear.

Just for Mimi.

Mimi looked up from her notebook slightly surprised.

Nothing had even happened.

She hadn't sighed dramatically.

Hadn't looked upset.

Hadn't said a single word.

But somehow Kiye noticed anyway.

Mimi nodded once.

Kiye studied her face for another second.

Then smiled softly before going back to her work.

Conversation over.

Yet somehow Mimi still felt understood.

That was the thing about Kiye.

She paid attention in ways most people didn't.

—

The friend group sat together outside during lunch again while warm wind moved through the trees around them.

Someone nearby played music too loudly from their phone speaker.

Maja complained dramatically about homework.

Naomi ignored her.

Mahia kept stealing everyone's snacks again.

And Kiye?

Kiye kept looking at Mimi every time something funny happened first.

Like instinct.

Like checking:

Did you hear that too?

At one point Maja attempted jumping over a bench and immediately failed horribly.

Everyone burst out laughing.

Kiye nearly fell sideways laughing herself while grabbing onto Mimi's arm dramatically.

And for a second neither of them could breathe properly from laughing too hard.

Tiny thing.

Again.

But Mimi loved those moments most.

The effortless ones.

—

Later during class, the teacher started discussing presentations for next week.

The entire room groaned instantly.

"I'd rather evaporate," Kiye whispered.

"You're being dramatic."

“I’m being honest.”

The teacher continued talking at the front while students complained quietly.

Then suddenly Kiye slid a sticky note onto Mimi’s desk.

if i embarrass myself during this presentation ur legally required to defend me

Mimi smiled before writing underneath:

depends how embarrassing it is

Kiye gasped dramatically after reading it.

Betrayal.

Fake heartbreak.

Overacted suffering.

Mimi laughed quietly to herself.

The language of best friends, apparently, included threatening emotional damage over presentations.

—

That afternoon, rain started pouring unexpectedly just as school ended.

Students crowded near exits complaining loudly.

“I didn’t bring an umbrella,” Mahia groaned.

“Neither did I,” Maja admitted.

Naomi sighed like a disappointed mother of four.

Meanwhile Kiye stood beside Mimi staring out at the rain thoughtfully.

Then without even asking, she shifted slightly closer beneath the tiny umbrella Mimi held.

Their shoulders pressed together naturally.

Warmth spreading through hoodie sleeves and shared space.

Tiny thing.

But Mimi felt it everywhere anyway.

“You know,” Kiye said suddenly, “if this rain gets worse we might actually perish.”

“Dramatic.”

“Realistic.”

Mimi smiled softly.

They started walking anyway, squeezing awkwardly beneath the umbrella while rain hammered against pavements around them.

Maja screamed every time cars splashed puddles nearby.

Aaliyah threatened violence repeatedly.

Naomi somehow still looked elegant despite the weather.

Chaos.

Warm chaos.

The best kind.

—

Halfway home, Kiye suddenly laughed quietly to herself.

“What?”

“You know we’ve reached best friend level now.”

Mimi blinked. “What does that mean?”

“You automatically give me the side of the pavement away from puddles.”

Mimi froze slightly.

Because... she did.

Without thinking.

Kiye grinned proudly.

“See? Friendship psychology.”

“That’s not psychology.”

“It’s love.”

The sentence landed casually.

Naturally.

Like breathing.

And maybe that was what made it affect Mimi so much.

Because Kiye loved people loudly.

Without embarrassment.

Without hesitation.

As if caring deeply for your friends was the easiest thing in the world.

Maybe it should’ve been.

—

That night, the group call lasted hours again.

Nobody actually planned conversations anymore.

They just happened.

Someone joined.

Then another person.

Then suddenly six people were screaming over each other while pretending to do homework.

Mimi stayed mostly quiet, listening while everyone argued about something stupid again.

At one point Kiye interrupted herself mid-sentence.

“Wait where did Mimi go?”

“I’m literally here.”

“Oh.”

Pause.

“Okay continue.”

Mimi laughed softly.

The thing was... Kiye always noticed when she got quiet.

Always checked.

Always looked.

Always remembered.

And maybe people underestimated how life-changing that could feel.

To be noticed.

—

Around midnight, the call slowly ended one by one until only Mimi and Kiye remained.

Comfortable silence filled the line for a while.

Then quietly, Kiye said:

“You know I can always tell when something’s wrong with you.”

Mimi looked down at her blanket.

“That’s slightly terrifying.”

“It’s because I know you.”

The words wrapped around Mimi’s chest softly.

Because maybe that was what becoming best friends really meant.

Learning someone’s silences.

Memorizing their moods.

Recognizing sadness before it was spoken aloud.

The language of best friends wasn’t complicated.

Sometimes it was just:

I know you.

And somehow, that meant everything.

Chapter Twelve

Playlist Songs & Shared Earphones 🎧

Some songs stopped being just songs after a while.

They became memories.

A certain lyric would suddenly remind you of a person.

A melody would feel like a specific afternoon.

A beat would sound like laughter echoing through hallways.

And unfortunately for Mimi, half her playlist was slowly becoming about Kiye.

—

“You have terrible music taste,” Kiye announced confidently one afternoon.

Mimi looked up in horror. “Excuse me?”

“I’m just being honest.”

“You listen to songs purely because they sound ‘aesthetic.’”

“And?”

“That is deeply concerning.”

Kiye gasped dramatically while clutching her chest.

Across the table, Naomi sighed. “Not this argument again.”

“It’s important,” Kiye defended.

“No,” Aaliyah corrected calmly, “it’s the same conversation every week.”

Mahia laughed. “Honestly they flirt through bullying at this point.”

Mimi nearly choked on her drink.

Kiye pointed immediately. "See? Even Mahia understands our bond."

"Our bond is me tolerating your nonsense."

"Exactly."

Maja fake wiped tears away. "Beautiful."

Everything dissolved into chaos again after that.

Normal.

Warm.

Loud.

The kind of afternoons Mimi already knew she'd miss one day.

—

Later during free period, the group spread themselves across the library floor pretending to revise.

Kiye sat beside Mimi scrolling through playlists instead.

"You NEED to hear this song."

"That sentence always scares me."

Kiye ignored her completely before handing over one earphone.

Tiny thing.

But Mimi's chest still tightened stupidly anyway.

Their shoulders brushed lightly as the song started.

Soft guitar.

Warm vocals.

The kind of song that sounded like nostalgia before nostalgia even existed yet.

Mimi listened quietly.

Then after a moment:

"Okay wait this is actually good."

Kiye looked personally victorious. "I know."

The song continued softly between them while rain tapped against library windows nearby.

And suddenly the moment felt strangely delicate.

Two girls sitting too close together sharing earphones while the rest of the world blurred into background noise.

Ordinary.

Yet somehow unforgettable.

—

"What does this song even remind you of?" Mimi asked quietly once it ended.

Kiye thought for a second.

Then smiled slightly.

"Us."

Simple answer.

Still, Mimi felt warmth spread through her chest instantly.

"Why?"

"I dunno," Kiye shrugged. "It just feels like friendship."

Mimi looked down at the earphone wire between them.
Because lately friendship itself had started feeling beautiful in ways she couldn't explain properly.
Not dramatic.
Not perfect.
Just soft.

—
That evening, Mimi reorganized her playlists for almost an hour.
Not intentionally emotional.
It just... happened.

One playlist became:
Songs That Feel Like Kiye
Another:
Late Night Calls & Overthinking
Another:
The Friend Group In Music Form

Most of the songs were random.
Some upbeat.
Some nostalgic.
Some painfully emotional.
But every single one carried memories now.
A song Kiye screamed dramatically during lunch.
A track everyone played too loudly during group calls.
Lyrics that suddenly sounded different after certain conversations.
Mimi smiled quietly while adding another song.
Then paused.
Because somewhere along the way, music itself had started feeling warmer too.

—
At school the next day, Kiye immediately stole Mimi's headphones.
"Rude," Mimi complained.
"You'll survive."
Kiye scrolled through songs dramatically.
Then suddenly froze.
"Oh my days."
"What?"
"You actually made a playlist about us."
Mimi's soul nearly left her body.
"You weren't supposed to SEE THAT."
Kiye looked delighted.
"THIS IS SO CUTE."

“Give me my phone back immediately.”

Kiye physically held it away while laughing.

“No because this one is called ‘songs that feel like home’ I’m actually emotional.”

Mimi covered her face instantly.

“Delete yourself.”

Kiye’s laughter softened slightly after a moment.

Then quieter:

“That’s genuinely really sweet though.”

Mimi looked away quickly because eye contact suddenly felt dangerous.

The thing about Kiye was that she always reacted to affection so sincerely.

Never mocking.

Never cruel.

Just soft.

Like caring deeply for people wasn’t embarrassing.

—

After school, the group walked slowly toward the park while sunset painted everything gold around them.

Someone played music quietly through a phone speaker.

Mahia danced badly.

Maja sang every lyric incorrectly on purpose.

Naomi threatened to leave repeatedly.

Meanwhile Kiye walked beside Mimi humming softly along to the song.

“You know what’s terrifying?” Kiye said suddenly.

“What?”

“One day these songs are gonna make us nostalgic.”

The sentence hit Mimi unexpectedly hard.

Because she knew Kiye was right.

Years from now they’d hear these tracks somewhere randomly and suddenly remember:

- crowded hallways,
- shared earphones,
- rainy afternoons,
- fourteen-year-old laughter,
- this exact version of each other.

And maybe growing up was just collecting future nostalgia without realizing it yet.

Mimi looked over quietly.

Golden sunlight caught against Kiye’s face while music played softly around them.

Beautiful.

Again.

Always beautiful.

Then Kiye smiled suddenly.

“What?”

“You’re staring.”
Mimi laughed softly.

“Maybe.”
Kiye grinned proudly at that like she’d won something.
And somehow the song playing in the background became another memory Mimi already knew she’d keep forever.

Chapter 12.5

Songs That Sound Like Us 🎵

Some people leave behind memories.
Kiye left behind soundtracks.
At some point, songs stopped being random background noise to Mimi. They became attached to moments. To laughter. To late-night conversations and blurry sunsets and voices overlapping during group calls.
Now every playlist felt like a scrapbook.
A collection of feelings too difficult to explain normally.
So Mimi started organizing them carefully.
Not because anyone asked her to.
Just because some emotions deserved their own soundtrack.

—

🌷 **PLAYLIST ONE**

Songs That Feel Like Kiye

Songs that reminded Mimi of warmth.
Of softness.
Of beauty that existed naturally without trying.
The first song on the playlist sounded like golden sunlight through curtains.
The second sounded like laughing until your stomach hurt.
The third sounded like standing beside someone who made the world feel safer automatically.
Mimi lay on her bedroom floor listening quietly while fairy lights glowed softly overhead.
Then she opened her notes app and typed:
Kiye feels like the bridge of a song you replay because it hurts beautifully.
She stared at the sentence for a second before smiling to herself.
Dramatic.
But true.

—

☁️ **PLAYLIST TWO**

Late Night Calls & Overthinking

This playlist sounded like:

- rain against windows,
- tired voices after midnight,
- “you still awake?” texts,

- emotional honesty that only appeared at 2am.

Songs for when the world felt quieter.

Songs that made Mimi think of hearing Kiye laugh softly through headphones while everyone else slowly left the group call one by one.

One track reminded her of the night Kiye admitted she was scared of growing up.

Another reminded her of shared silence that somehow never felt awkward.

Another sounded exactly like comfort.

Mimi saved all of them carefully.

Because one day these songs would probably hurt to hear.

Not in a bad way.

Just in the way memories always did once time passed.

—

 PLAYLIST THREE

The Friend Group In Music Form

Every person had their own song.

Aaliyah

Songs that sounded protective.

Warm.

Steady.

Naomi

Elegant songs that felt wise somehow.

Maja

Loud chaotic songs that somehow still made you emotional afterward.

Mahia

Sweet songs filled with affection and soft energy.

Kiye...

Mimi paused there for a while.

Because no single song fully captured Kiye.

Some tracks sounded like her laugh.

Others sounded like her kindness.

Others sounded like how safe she made people feel.

Eventually Mimi just added all of them.

—

One afternoon during free period, Kiye stole one of Mimi’s earphones again.

“You literally live inside playlists,” she teased.

“You literally talk during every emotional song.”

“Because silence scares me.”

Mimi laughed quietly.

Then the next song started playing.

Soft piano.

Gentle lyrics.
The kind of song that made your chest ache without fully understanding why.
Kiye went unusually quiet listening to it.
“This one’s sad,” she whispered eventually.

“Sad-happy,” Mimi corrected softly.

Kiye looked over.

“What’s the difference?”

Mimi thought for a second.

Then answered honestly.

“Sad songs make you hurt.”

“And sad-happy songs?”

Mimi smiled faintly.

“They make you remember.”

For a moment neither of them spoke.

The song continued quietly between shared earphones while the library buzzed softly around them.

And somehow the silence felt important.

—

PLAYLIST FOUR

Songs I Could Never Explain Properly

These were the dangerous songs.

The ones that felt too honest.

Songs that reminded Mimi of:

- looking for Kiye automatically in crowded rooms,
- smiling at notifications,
- becoming attached to ordinary moments because she was inside them.

One particular lyric nearly ruined her emotionally every time she heard it.

Not because it was romantic.

Because it sounded exactly like loving someone platonically with your entire heart.

The terrifying kind of friendship-love that made you want to preserve moments forever because you already knew time moved too quickly.

Mimi added the song anyway.

Of course she did.

—

That night, while reorganizing playlists again instead of sleeping like a normal person, Mimi renamed one final playlist.

Originally it had been called:

Favourite Songs

Now she changed it to:

If Our Friendship Had A Soundtrack

She stared at the title quietly afterward.

Then pressed play.

Music filled the room softly while rain tapped against the windows outside.

And suddenly Mimi realized something.
Maybe one day they’d all grow older.
Maybe these songs would become nostalgic.
Maybe hearing them years later would ache in beautiful ways.
But right now?
Right now they were fourteen.
Still loud.
Still soft.

Still becoming part of each other’s lives in tiny unforgettable ways.
And maybe that was enough.
Before sleeping, Mimi opened her notes app one last time and typed:
If someone asked me what Kiye sounded like, I think I’d hand them this playlist.
Then beneath it:
Some people leave behind echoes.
She leaves behind entire soundtracks.

Chapter Thirteen

Matching Bracelets 🎀

It started as a joke.
Most important things did with them.
—

“These are literally us,” Mahia announced dramatically one afternoon while holding up a set of bracelets in the middle of the shopping centre.
Everyone crowded closer instantly.
The bracelets were simple:
tiny beads,
soft colours,
little silver stars threaded between them.
Cute enough to immediately cause emotional damage.

“Oh no,” Naomi sighed quietly. “I can already see where this is going.”
“We need matching ones,” Maja declared.
“Absolutely not,” Aaliyah replied automatically.
Five minutes later everyone was choosing bracelets anyway.
—

The little shop smelled faintly like perfume and paper packaging while music played softly overhead.
Mahia and Maja argued over colours immediately.
Naomi somehow managed to make even bracelet shopping look elegant.
Aaliyah kept pretending she didn’t care despite clearly caring the most.
And Kiye?
Kiye stood beside Mimi comparing different bracelets carefully like this was a life-changing decision.

“This one’s cute.”

“It’s literally neon green.”

“Exactly.”

“That’s horrifying.”

Kiye gasped dramatically. “You hate joy.”

Mimi laughed quietly while looking through the display.

Then her eyes landed on one bracelet tucked near the back.

Soft white beads.

Tiny gold stars.

Simple.

Warm-looking somehow.

“Kiye,” Mimi said softly, holding it up.

Kiye looked over.

Then smiled immediately.

“Oh wait.”

For a second neither of them said anything.

Because somehow the bracelet just *fe/t* right.

Not loud.

Not dramatic.

Soft.

Like them.

—

Eventually everyone bought matching bracelets anyway despite Aaliyah’s fake complaints.

Maja immediately held hers up emotionally.

“If we drift apart one day I’ll actually become tragic.”

“Why would you say that?” Mahia cried.

“I’m expressing emotions!”

Naomi sighed deeply. “You’re all exhausting.”

But even she smiled while fastening her bracelet carefully around her wrist.

Mimi glanced down at hers quietly.

The tiny gold stars caught softly beneath the lights.

Beside her, Kiye fastened her own bracelet before holding her wrist out proudly.

“Cute.”

Mimi smiled. “Yeah.”

Then suddenly Kiye grabbed Mimi’s hand without warning, comparing the bracelets side by side.

Tiny thing.

Again.

Always tiny things.

Still, Mimi’s chest tightened around the warmth of it anyway.

“Now we’re officially attached forever,” Kiye announced dramatically.

“Concerning.”

“Beautiful actually.”

Maybe both.

—

Over the next few weeks, the bracelets quietly became part of everyday life.

Tiny pieces of each other carried everywhere.

Mimi noticed all the little moments:

- Kiye absentmindedly spinning the bracelet while thinking,
- Mahia matching hers with outfits dramatically,
- Maja pretending the bracelet gave her “special powers.”

One afternoon during maths, Kiye looked over suddenly.

“You still wear yours every day.”

Mimi blinked. “Obviously?”

Kiye smiled softly at that.

“I dunno. Some people stop caring about stuff like this after a week.”

Mimi looked down at the bracelet around her wrist.

The beads had already started loosening slightly from constant wear.

But somehow that made it feel more important.

Loved things always showed signs of being loved eventually.

“I like keeping it on,” Mimi admitted quietly.

Kiye’s smile softened again.

“Me too.”

And for a second the moment felt strangely fragile.

Like one of those tiny memories Mimi already knew she’d carry for years.

—

One rainy evening, the group sat together on call while everyone supposedly worked on homework.

Nobody actually focused.

Maja started singing badly halfway through.

Naomi threatened to leave the call repeatedly.

Mahia somehow spilled juice everywhere.

Chaos.

Warm chaos.

At some point, Kiye suddenly held her wrist up to the camera.

“Look how pretty the bracelet looks in this lighting.”

Mimi laughed softly.

“Only you would turn friendship bracelets into a photoshoot.”

“As I should.”

Then quieter, almost absentmindedly, Kiye added:

“I really love this though.”

Something about the sentence settled deeply inside Mimi’s chest.
Because the bracelet wasn’t really about jewellery anymore.
It was proof.
Proof that they existed together during this part of life.
Proof that these moments were real.
Proof that fourteen-year-old friendship could feel this deep and beautiful and important.

—

Later that night, while taking off rings beside her mirror, Mimi paused looking at the bracelet again.
Tiny gold stars.
Slightly worn beads.
A little imperfect already.
Still beautiful.
She touched it gently before opening her notes app.
Another habit now.
Then typed:

Maybe friendship is just collecting tiny proofs that you loved each other here.
After a second, she added:
Matching bracelets. Shared playlists. Saved screenshots. Late-night conversations.
Then finally:
Tiny things become important when the people attached to them are important too.

Mimi stared at the words quietly while fairy lights glowed around her room.
The bracelet rested warm against her wrist.
And somehow that small feeling of connection made the whole world feel softer again.

Chapter Fourteen

The Day Kiye Cried ☁️💧

Mimi had seen Kiye emotional before.
Laughing too hard until tears appeared.
Fake dramatic crying over embarrassing things.
Getting sentimental over songs at unreasonable hours of the night.
But she had never seen her truly upset.
Not properly.
Until Thursday.

—

Something felt off immediately.
Kiye arrived late to school for the first time in weeks.
No dramatic entrance.
No loud “guess what happened.”
No chaotic energy filling the hallway before she even reached the group.

Just quiet footsteps and tired eyes.

Mimi noticed instantly.

Of course she did.

"You okay?" she asked softly as Kiye dropped into the seat beside her.

"Yeah."

Too quick.

Too automatic.

Mimi frowned slightly.

Usually Kiye would've joked afterward.

Teased her.

Said something dramatic.

This time she just looked down at her desk instead.

And suddenly the whole classroom felt heavier somehow.

—

Throughout the morning, everyone noticed pieces of it.

Kiye laughed less.

Spoke less.

Kept zoning out during conversations.

Even Maja stopped making jokes about it eventually.

At lunch, the group sat outside beneath grey cloudy skies while cold wind moved through the trees around them.

Nobody really knew what to say.

Kiye picked quietly at her food while everyone else pretended not to notice she barely touched it.

Then Mahia gently nudged a packet of sweets toward her.

"Eat before you evaporate dramatically."

Normally Kiye would've laughed.

This time she only smiled faintly.

And for some reason, that hurt worse.

—

Later during English, students worked silently while rain tapped softly against classroom windows.

Mimi kept glancing over.

Kiye stared blankly at her page, pen unmoving.

Then suddenly the teacher asked her a question.

A simple one.

But Kiye froze.

Just for a second.

Long enough for the whole room to notice.

"I—sorry," she mumbled quietly. "I wasn't listening."

The teacher moved on kindly enough.

Still, Mimi saw the embarrassment flash across Kiye's face immediately afterward.

Saw the way she looked down quickly.
And something inside Mimi’s chest tightened painfully.

—
When the bell rang, everyone started flooding noisily into hallways again.
But before Mimi could stand properly, Kiye grabbed her sleeve lightly.

“Can we go somewhere?”
Her voice sounded small.
That scared Mimi more than anything.
“Yeah,” she answered immediately.

—
They ended up sitting in an empty stairwell near the back of the school where hardly anyone went.
Rain echoed softly outside.
Distant hallway noise blurred somewhere far away.
For a while neither of them spoke.
Kiye sat beside her hugging her knees quietly.
And suddenly Mimi realized something terrifying.
Kiye always took care of everyone else.
But who took care of Kiye?

—
“You don’t have to talk if you don’t want to,” Mimi said gently after a while.
Kiye nodded slightly.
Then immediately started crying anyway.
Not dramatic crying.
Not movie crying.
The quiet kind.
The kind people tried hardest to hide.
Mimi’s heart cracked instantly.
“Oh,” she whispered softly.
Without thinking, she moved closer.
Kiye covered her face quickly like she felt embarrassed.
“I’m sorry,” she laughed shakily through tears. “This is so stupid.”
“It’s not stupid.”
“I literally don’t even know why I’m crying anymore.”
Her voice broke slightly at the end.
And somehow hearing Kiye sound fragile felt deeply wrong to Mimi.
Like seeing sunlight apologize for not shining enough.
“You don’t always have to hold everything together,” Mimi whispered.
Kiye looked down silently.
Rain continued tapping softly against the windows nearby.

Then quietly, barely above a whisper, Kiye admitted:

“I’m tired.”

Two words.

Still, they carried everything.

Mimi swallowed hard.

Because suddenly she understood.

Not physically tired.

Emotionally tired.

The heavier kind.

The kind that made even small things feel impossible sometimes.

So instead of trying to fix it, Mimi just stayed there beside her.

No huge speech.

No forced positivity.

Just presence.

Sometimes people needed that more.

—

After a while, Kiye laughed weakly while wiping her face.

“You’re seeing me at my flop era.”

Mimi smiled softly. “You’re still pretty.”

Kiye groaned immediately. “This is actually humiliating.”

“You literally look beautiful crying too. It’s annoying honestly.”

That finally made Kiye laugh properly.

Small.

But real.

“There she is,” Mimi whispered quietly.

Kiye looked over at her then.

Eyes still glassy.

Sleeves pulled over her hands.

Soft sadness lingering around her anyway.

And somehow Mimi felt her chest ache with affection so intense it almost scared her.

Because how could someone be this loved without fully realizing it?

—

Eventually, the bell forced them both back toward reality.

Kiye stood slowly beside the stairwell door while fixing her sleeves awkwardly.

Then suddenly she looked at Mimi.

“Thank you.”

Simple words.

Still heavy somehow.

Mimi shook her head slightly. “You never have to thank me for staying.”

For a second Kiye just stared at her quietly.

Then, without warning, she wrapped her arms around Mimi tightly.

Tiny thing.

Not tiny at all, actually.

Mimi hugged her back immediately.

And for a moment the world outside disappeared completely.

Just warmth.

Rain.

Softness.

The feeling of being trusted with someone’s sadness.

When they finally pulled apart, Kiye smiled faintly.

“You’re very easy to need,” she admitted quietly.

The sentence stayed with Mimi long after that day ended.

Because maybe love wasn’t always loud declarations.

Maybe sometimes it was simply this:

Sitting beside someone in their worst moments and making sure they didn’t feel alone there.

Chapter Fifteen

Photos Taken By Kiye 📷

Kiye took photos of everything.

Not serious photography.

Just random moments people normally forgot about.

Half-eaten food.

Blurry sunsets.

Mahia laughing mid-sentence.

Maja tripping over absolutely nothing.

And recently, Mimi had unfortunately become one of her favourite subjects.

—

“Delete that immediately.”

“No.”

“Kiye.”

“It’s art.”

Mimi groaned while trying to grab Kiye’s phone across the lunch table.

Kiye held it out of reach dramatically while laughing.

“You can’t just take photos without warning!”

“I literally can.”

“That’s terrifying.”

“Actually it’s beautiful.”

Naomi looked up from her book briefly. “You’ve taken approximately four hundred photos of Mimi this week.”

“Documenting history,” Kiye defended calmly.

Maja gasped dramatically. “Oh my days she’s obsessed.”

“I AM NOT.”

“You took a candid photo of her tying her shoelace yesterday,” Mahia added.

Kiye paused.

Then shrugged. “The lighting was nice.”

Everyone burst out laughing.

Meanwhile Mimi sat there trying very hard not to smile too much.

Because honestly?

Being noticed by Kiye felt dangerously nice.

—

The thing about Kiye’s photos was that they were never perfect.

She loved movement too much for that.

Most pictures came out blurry around the edges:

people laughing too hard,

hands moving mid-conversation,

sunlight spilling unevenly across faces.

But somehow that made them feel more alive.

More real.

One afternoon after school, the group sat together in the park again while golden evening light covered everything softly.

Mahia braided flowers into Aaliyah’s hair dramatically.

Naomi pretended not to enjoy it.

Maja attempted cartwheels with horrifying results.

Normal chaos.

Mimi sat quietly on the grass watching everyone while music played faintly nearby.

Then:

click.

She looked over instantly.

“Kiye.”

Kiye lowered her phone innocently. “What?”

“You just took another photo.”

“Maybe.”

“Why?”

Kiye looked at the picture for a second before answering.

“You looked happy.”

The sentence hit Mimi gently right in the chest.

Again.

Because somehow Kiye always noticed happiness like it was something precious worth preserving.

—

Later that evening, Kiye spammed the group chat with the day’s photos.

Most were ridiculous.

Maja mid-fall.

Mahia laughing with her whole body.

Aaliyah threatening violence in at least three separate pictures.

Then Mimi’s phone buzzed privately.

A message from Kiye.

Attached was the photo from earlier.

Mimi opened it quietly.

Golden sunlight.

Messy hair from the wind.

A soft smile she hadn’t even realized she was wearing.

For a moment she just stared.

Then another message appeared beneath it.

Kiye:

thats my favourite picture of u i think

Mimi felt warmth flood through her chest instantly.

Mimi:

why?

Typing...

Kiye:

because u look peaceful

Mimi looked back at the photo again afterward.

Peaceful.

Maybe she did.

And maybe part of that peace existed because Kiye had become woven into her life now.

Into her routines.

Her happiness.

Her ordinary days.

—

The next morning at school, Kiye arrived holding an iced drink dramatically like she’d survived battle.

“I’m exhausted.”

“You say this every day.”

“Because school is emotionally violent.”

Mimi laughed softly.

Then Kiye suddenly pulled out her phone again.

“Oh wait stand there.”

“What now?”

“The sunlight looks pretty.”

Mimi sighed dramatically but stayed still anyway.

Kiye snapped the photo quickly.

Then smiled.

“Perfect.”

“You didn’t even check it.”

“I don’t need to.”

The confidence in her voice made Mimi weirdly shy suddenly.

Which was ridiculous.

It was literally just Kiye.

Except somehow “just Kiye” had started meaning everything lately.

—

At lunch, Naomi scrolled through Kiye’s camera roll accidentally.

Then paused.

“Oh my god.”

Kiye looked horrified instantly. “DON’T EXPOSE ME.”

Too late.

Naomi turned the phone around toward everyone dramatically.

The entire camera roll was full of the friend group.

Tiny moments.

Random laughter.

Screenshots from calls.

Blurry memories.

And Mimi appeared in almost all of them.

Maja screamed immediately.

“Kiye this is actually insane behaviour.”

“It’s MEMORY KEEPING.”

“It’s obsession.”

Kiye grabbed her phone back dramatically while everyone laughed.

But secretly, Mimi’s chest hurt softly looking at all those pictures.

Because the photos proved something she’d already been feeling for months now.

These people mattered to each other deeply.

Enough to preserve ordinary moments before they disappeared.

Enough to keep evidence of happiness.

—

That night, Mimi scrolled through her own camera roll slowly.

And she realized something.

Kiye existed everywhere inside it too now.

Saved accidentally into everyday life.

Photos of bracelets.

Screenshots of messages.
Blurry pictures from lunch tables and rainy afternoons.
Proof.
Tiny proofs that this friendship existed.
Mimi smiled quietly before opening her notes app again.
Then typed:
Kiye photographs people the way she loves them.
Softly. Honestly. Like she’s afraid to forget them.
After a moment, she added:
Maybe that’s why her photos feel warm.
Mimi reread the sentence beneath dim fairy lights while rain whispered softly outside.
And somewhere in another house, Kiye was probably saving another blurry memory already.

Chapter Sixteen

The Fear Of Growing Apart 🌙

Nobody warns you that growing up feels strange while it’s happening.
One minute you’re laughing in school hallways like nothing could ever change.
The next, someone casually mentions the future and suddenly your chest hurts for reasons you can’t explain properly.
—
It started during lunch.
The group sat crowded around their usual table near the windows while sunlight spilled across trays and water bottles.
Maja talked dramatically about future careers she’d never realistically survive in.
“I could totally be famous.”
“You cried trying to order food last week,” Naomi reminded her calmly.
“That was performance anxiety.”
“That was because you forgot what nuggets were called,” Aaliyah corrected.
Everyone laughed.
Then Mahia suddenly asked:
“Wait do you guys actually know what you wanna do when you’re older?”
The conversation shifted immediately after that.
Naomi talked about plans seriously.
Aaliyah already sounded more organized than half the adults they knew.
Maja changed her answer every thirty seconds.
Normal.
But Mimi noticed Kiye growing quieter beside her.
Tiny thing.
Still noticeable.
—
Later during class, while everyone worked independently, Kiye stared out the window thoughtfully.

Rain rolled softly down the glass outside.

"You okay?" Mimi whispered.

"Hm?"

"You disappeared again."

Kiye looked back toward her slowly.

Then after a second:

"Do you ever think about how weird it's gonna be when we're older?"

Mimi paused slightly.

"All the time."

Kiye rested her chin against her sleeve.

"I hate it."

The honesty in her voice made something ache inside Mimi's chest.

Because she understood.

Too well.

The terrifying thing about loving people deeply was realizing time kept moving anyway.

One day:

different schools,

different cities,

different lives.

The thought felt unbearable sometimes.

—

After school, the sky looked pale grey while everyone walked slowly toward the bus stop together.

The conversation moved lazily around them.

But Mimi noticed Kiye staying closer than usual.

Quiet.

Thoughtful.

At one point, while the others argued ahead over music again, Kiye spoke softly beside her.

"What if we all drift apart one day?"

Mimi looked over immediately.

Wind moved gently through Kiye's hair while she stared down at the pavement.

And suddenly she looked younger somehow.

Not the loud funny version everyone usually saw.

Just fourteen.

Just scared.

"You really think that'll happen?" Mimi asked quietly.

"I dunno."

Kiye shrugged weakly.

"People always say friendships change when you grow up."

Mimi hated how sad the sentence sounded.

Because maybe it was true.

But she didn't want it to be.

Not this friendship.

Not these people.

Not Kiye.

—

That evening, the group call felt softer than usual.

Less chaotic.

Everyone sounded tired in the comfortable way that came after long days.

At some point the conversation drifted toward memories.

Favourite moments together.

Embarrassing stories.

Things everyone secretly appreciated about each other.

Maja got emotional first, obviously.

"I actually love you guys so much."

"Here she goes," Naomi sighed fondly.

"No because I'm serious," Maja continued dramatically. "If any of you disappear I'll become tragic."

Mahia laughed softly. "You already are tragic."

"Rude."

But underneath the jokes, everyone understood the feeling.

The strange sadness of knowing moments couldn't stay exactly the same forever.

—

Eventually, people started leaving the call one by one until only Mimi and Kiye remained again.

Comfortable silence filled the space between them.

Then quietly, Kiye admitted:

"I'm scared of becoming one of those people who says 'we should catch up sometime' and never actually does."

Mimi swallowed hard.

Because somehow that specific fear felt devastatingly real.

The idea of Kiye becoming distant someday felt wrong in a way she couldn't explain.

"You won't," Mimi said softly.

"You don't know that."

"I kinda do."

Kiye laughed weakly through the speaker.

"How?"

Mimi thought for a second before answering honestly.

"Because some people only exist in certain parts of your life."

Pause.

Then quieter:

"And some people become part of you."

Silence.

Heavy.

Soft.

Important.

Finally Kiye whispered:

“That was disgustingly emotional.”

Mimi smiled to herself.

“You started it.”

“I know.”

Another pause.

Then:

“You’re part of me too, by the way.”

The sentence wrapped itself around Mimi’s chest gently.

Because maybe that was the real fear growing up created.

Not just losing people.

But losing versions of yourself attached to them.

And lately, so much of Mimi’s happiness had Kiye woven into it.

—

That night, long after the call ended, Mimi sat by her window watching streetlights glow against wet pavements outside.

Her bracelet rested warm against her wrist.

Music played softly through headphones.

The world felt strangely quiet.

Then she opened her notes app again.

And typed:

I think the scariest thing about growing up is realizing moments end while you’re still inside them.

After a moment, she added:

But maybe some people stay with you anyway.

Even after everything changes.

Mimi stared at the words for a while beneath dim fairy lights.

Then finally, one last sentence:

I hope Kiye stays in every version of my future.

Chapter Seventeen

Sleepovers & 3AM Conversations

There was something magical about sleepovers.

Not the movie version with perfect matching pajamas and polished rooms.

Real sleepovers.

Half-open snack packets everywhere.

Messy blankets piled across the floor.

Music playing too quietly from someone’s phone while everyone tried not to wake parents upstairs.

The kind where conversations somehow became more honest after midnight.

—

“This is actually disgusting,” Naomi announced while staring at the amount of snacks covering Aaliyah’s bedroom floor.

Maja gasped dramatically. “This is culture.”

“This is diabetes.”

Mahia laughed while opening another packet anyway.

Meanwhile Kiye sat cross-legged beside Mimi attempting — and failing — to untangle fairy lights from around her own arm.

“How did you even do this?” Mimi asked.

“I have gifts.”

“Your gift is causing problems.”

“Exactly.”

The room glowed softly gold beneath string lights while rain tapped gently outside the windows.

Warmth existed everywhere:

inside laughter,

inside overlapping conversations,

inside the comfortable chaos of being fourteen and together.

Mimi wished quietly that moments like this could last forever.

—

At first, the night stayed loud.

Movies nobody paid attention to.

Terrible singing.

Maja exposing everyone’s embarrassing stories against their will.

At one point Kiye nearly fell off the mattress laughing so hard she couldn’t breathe properly.

“You’re actually dying,” Mahia wheezed.

“This is how legends go out.”

“You slipped on a hoodie.”

“LET ME HAVE MY DRAMA.”

Everyone dissolved into laughter again.

Mimi smiled so hard her face hurt.

Because this right here —

this exact moment —

felt like happiness before people even realized it was happiness.

—

By 2AM, the room finally softened.

Music lowered.

Voices quieter now.

Everyone wrapped loosely in blankets and exhaustion.

Naomi and Aaliyah whispered about something near the window.

Mahia scrolled sleepily through playlists.

Maja somehow still had energy left for dramatic storytelling.

And Kiye?

Kiye lay beside Mimi staring at the ceiling.

“You awake?” she whispered quietly.

“You’re literally talking to me.”

“Fair point.”

Mimi laughed softly.

The fairy lights cast warm shadows across the room while rain continued tapping gently outside.

Everything felt strangely peaceful.

Then Kiye spoke again.

“Do you think we’ll remember nights like this forever?”

Mimi turned her head slightly toward her.

Kiye’s face looked softer in dim lighting somehow.

Sleepy.

Thoughtful.

“Yeah,” Mimi answered honestly.

“How do you know?”

Mimi thought for a second.

“Because I already know I’ll miss this someday.”

The sentence settled quietly between them.

Not sad exactly.

Just true.

—

For a while neither of them spoke again.

Then suddenly Kiye whispered:

“I really love our friendship.”

Mimi’s chest hurt softly.

Because Kiye said things like that so naturally sometimes.

Like affection wasn’t something to hide from.

“Me too,” Mimi whispered back.

“No but seriously.”

Kiye rolled slightly onto her side now, blanket pulled up to her chin.

“You make life feel easier.”

The honesty in her voice made Mimi’s throat tighten unexpectedly.

“You do that for me too,” she admitted quietly.

Kiye smiled faintly.

Then after a second:

“You know what’s weird?”

“What?”

“I think if I met younger versions of us, they’d be happy we found each other.”

Mimi blinked slightly.

Because somehow that sentence felt too beautiful for 3AM.

And yet perfectly Kiye at the same time.

—

Across the room, Maja suddenly sat up dramatically.

“WHY ARE YOU TWO HAVING AN INDIE MOVIE CONVERSATION.”

Everyone burst into exhausted laughter instantly.

Kiye threw a pillow at her.

“GO TO SLEEP.”

“I CAN FEEL THE EMOTIONS.”

Naomi groaned. “Maja if you don’t lower your voice right now—”

Chaos returned briefly after that.

Warm chaos.

The kind only best friends created together.

—

Eventually, one by one, everyone actually started falling asleep.

Music continued softly in the background.

Rain tapped steadily against the windows.

Fairy lights glowed faintly above tired faces.

Mimi lay awake for a little longer listening to everyone breathe quietly around the room.

And for a moment, the realization hit her all over again.

One day this would become nostalgia.

This exact room.

These exact people.

This exact version of themselves.

Fourteen.

Sleepy.

Loud.

Loved.

The thought hurt beautifully.

Beside her, Kiye shifted sleepily under the blankets.

Then half-awake, voice barely above a whisper, she mumbled:

“Night Mimi.”

Mimi smiled softly into the darkness.

“Night Kiye.”

A pause.

Then very quietly:

“Love you.”

The words arrived naturally.

Sleepily.

Without hesitation.

Mimi felt warmth spread through her chest instantly.

“Love you too,” she whispered back.

And somehow, beneath fairy lights and rain and the soft breathing of everyone she loved most, the world felt gentle enough to fall asleep inside.

Chapter Eighteen

The Little Things Kiye Remembers 🌻

Mimi started noticing something strange about Kiye.

She remembered everything.

Not big obvious things.

Little things.

The kinds of details most people heard once and forgot immediately afterward.

And somehow, Kiye collected them all without even trying.

—

It started with tiny moments.

“You hate orange juice with bits.”

Mimi blinked. “How do you know that?”

“You made a disgusted face drinking it once.”

Or:

“You always get quieter when you’re overwhelmed.”

And:

“You smile differently when you’re genuinely happy.”

Every time Kiye casually mentioned something like that, Mimi felt the same warmth spread through her chest.

Because being remembered so carefully was a special kind of love.

—

One afternoon after school, the group stopped at a café near the shopping centre.

Rain drizzled softly outside while warm lighting wrapped around the little tables inside.

Maja nearly dropped her drink immediately.

Naomi looked disappointed in everyone already.

Mahia kept stealing fries from people’s plates like survival depended on it.

Normal.

Mimi sat beside Kiye scrolling absentmindedly through her phone until the waiter arrived.

Before Mimi could even speak, Kiye looked up and said:

“She doesn’t like whipped cream on hers.”

Mimi paused.

The waiter nodded and walked away.

Then slowly Mimi turned toward her.

“You remembered that?”

Kiye looked confused. “Yeah?”

“Why?”

Kiye shrugged casually.

“Because you always scrape it off anyway.”

Simple answer.

Still, Mimi’s chest tightened softly around it.

Because the thing was —

Kiye remembered details people usually overlooked.

Like they mattered.

Like *you* mattered.

—

Later that evening during the group call, the conversation somehow turned toward favourite songs again.

Mahia played emotional music dramatically.

Maja judged everyone’s playlists loudly.

Aaliyah threatened to mute the entire call.

Meanwhile Kiye interrupted suddenly.

“Wait Mimi this song sounds like your favourite colour.”

Silence.

Then Naomi sighed.

“That sentence somehow makes sense.”

“It DOES,” Kiye defended immediately.

Mimi laughed quietly.

“What does my favourite colour even sound like?”

Kiye thought for a second.

“Soft.”

Mimi stared at the screen for a moment.

Because honestly?

That sounded exactly like something only Kiye would say.

—

A few days later, everyone sat outside during lunch while cold wind moved through the school courtyard.

Mimi had barely spoken all morning.

Not intentionally.

Her energy just felt low again.

The group talked around her comfortably anyway.

Then without warning, Kiye slid a packet of sour sweets onto her lap.

Mimi looked over.

“You looked like you needed these.”

Tiny thing.

Again.

Always tiny things.

But suddenly Mimi realized something.

Kiye didn't just remember favourite drinks or random habits.

She remembered moods too.

Silences.

Expressions.

The tiny changes in people before they even explained themselves.

And maybe that was why people felt safe around her.

Because she paid attention gently.

—

After school, the sky glowed pale pink while everyone slowly walked toward the bus stop together.

Maja and Mahia argued dramatically ahead.

Naomi kept correcting them.

Aaliyah looked seconds away from abandoning everyone entirely.

Meanwhile Kiye walked beside Mimi unusually quietly.

Then suddenly:

"You didn't sleep properly last night."

Mimi nearly tripped.

"What?"

"You're doing the tired blink thing."

"The WHAT?"

Kiye laughed softly.

"You do this slow blink when you're exhausted."

Mimi stared at her in horror.

"That's terrifyingly observant."

"I know you."

There it was again.

Those three words.

Simple.

Still dangerous somehow.

Because lately Mimi kept realizing just how deeply Kiye paid attention to her.

And the terrifying thing?

Mimi paid attention right back.

—

That night, Mimi sat at her desk pretending to revise while music played quietly through headphones.

Instead, she kept thinking about all the tiny things Kiye remembered.

Favourite snacks.

Sleep habits.
Mood shifts.
Expressions.
Little pieces of her collected carefully over time.
Then suddenly her phone buzzed.

Kiye:

did u eat yet

Mimi smiled automatically.

Mimi:

yes mum

Kiye:

good because if u pass away from forgetting meals ill be annoyed

Mimi laughed softly to herself.

Then another message arrived.

Kiye:

also dont stay awake too late tonight

Mimi stared at the screen quietly.

Because even through simple texts, Kiye somehow made caring feel warm instead of overwhelming.

Like love existed best in ordinary reminders.

Eat properly.

Sleep enough.

Text me when you get home.

Tiny things.

Still important.

—

Before sleeping, Mimi opened her notes app again.

Then typed slowly:

I think one of the purest forms of love is remembering small details about someone.

After a second, she added:

Kiye remembers people carefully.

Like forgetting them was never an option.

Mimi reread the sentence beneath dim fairy lights while rain whispered softly outside.

And somewhere deep inside her chest, something softened all over again.

Chapter Nineteen

The Hoodie Incident

The problem with Kiye was that she stole things casually.

Not actual stealing.

More like:

hoodies,
rings,
hair ties,
snacks,
people’s emotional stability.

And unfortunately for Mimi, she seemed especially attached to stealing *her* things lately.

—

“This is mine now.”

“Kiye.”

“No take-backs.”

Mimi stared in disbelief as Kiye casually walked through the school hallway wearing her hoodie like she personally bought it herself.

“You literally stole that off my chair.”

“I borrowed it.”

“You didn’t ask.”

“You would’ve said no.”

“Exactly!”

Kiye grinned proudly while pulling the sleeves over her hands dramatically.

Across the hallway, Maja looked personally delighted.

“Oh this is getting SICKENING now.”

Mahia immediately agreed. “That is relationship behaviour.”

“It’s friendship behaviour,” Kiye defended.

Naomi looked up from her phone briefly.

“It’s definitely something.”

Mimi felt her face grow warm instantly.

Because honestly?

Seeing Kiye in her hoodie was affecting her emotionally more than it should’ve.

Which was embarrassing.

Very embarrassing.

—

The thing was, Kiye looked good in everything.

Oversized hoodies.

Messy uniforms.

Random jewellery combinations that should not have worked but somehow did anyway.

And now she was walking around school wearing Mimi’s hoodie like it belonged there.

“This is actually evil,” Mimi muttered quietly.

Kiye looked over immediately.

“What?”

“You look too comfortable.”

“Because I *am* comfortable.”

Then softer:

“It smells like you.”

Mimi nearly stopped functioning entirely.

Meanwhile Maja screamed loud enough to attract attention from nearby students.

“OH MY DAYS.”

“Kiye shut UP,” Mimi whispered aggressively while trying not to laugh.

Kiye just looked deeply amused with herself.

—

At lunch, Kiye still refused to return the hoodie.

“It’s cold.”

“You own clothes.”

“None with emotional significance.”

“That sentence made me physically ill.”

Mahia laughed so hard she nearly dropped her drink.

Aaliyah shook her head slowly. “You two are exhausting.”

But secretly, Mimi didn’t actually want the hoodie back immediately.

Because every time she looked over and saw Kiye wrapped inside it, something warm spread quietly through her chest.

Like seeing pieces of herself attached to Kiye somehow.

Soft.

Comforting.

Dangerous.

—

Later during science, the classroom felt freezing.

Students complained dramatically while pretending to work.

Kiye sat beside Mimi absentmindedly playing with the sleeve of the hoodie.

Then suddenly she smiled slightly.

“What?”

“This is weirdly comforting.”

Mimi looked over quietly.

The sleeves covered half Kiye’s hands.

Her bracelet peeked out beneath the fabric.

She looked soft somehow.

Safe.

And for one terrifying second, Mimi had the overwhelming urge to preserve the moment forever.

“You can keep it for today,” she mumbled eventually.

Kiye looked genuinely pleased by that.

“Aw.”

“Don’t make it emotional.”

“Too late.”

—

After school, rain poured heavily outside again.

Everyone crowded near the entrance waiting for it to calm down.

Maja complained dramatically about her hair.

Naomi ignored her entirely.

Mahia filmed the rain aesthetically for no reason.

Meanwhile Kiye leaned beside Mimi quietly.

Then after a second:

“You know what your hoodie feels like?”

“What?”

“Getting hugged.”

The sentence hit Mimi straight in the chest.

Because maybe it sounded silly.

Maybe it was just a hoodie.

But somehow Kiye always turned small things into feelings.

And suddenly Mimi understood why moments with her stayed in people’s hearts so long afterward.

—

Eventually they walked home through the rain anyway.

Kiye still wore the hoodie.

Mimi pretended not to notice every time she pulled the sleeves over her hands against the cold.

Pretended not to notice how weirdly right it looked.

At one point Kiye glanced over suddenly.

“You know I’m never giving this back.”

“You’re actually evil.”

“You love me.”

Unfortunately true.

—

That night, Mimi opened her wardrobe searching for another hoodie before realizing the missing one had been her favourite.

Normal people probably would’ve been annoyed.

Instead, she just smiled quietly to herself.

Then her phone buzzed.

A photo from Kiye.

She’d taken a mirror selfie wearing the hoodie with the caption:

currently thriving btw

Mimi laughed softly.

Then another message arrived immediately after:

your hoodie smells comforting

thats lowkey adorable of u

Mimi stared at the screen in disbelief.

Mimi:

give me my hoodie back actually

Kiye:

never

Then:

Kiye:

also thank u for letting me keep it today

The softness of the message settled gently inside Mimi’s chest.

Because underneath all the teasing and chaos, Kiye always noticed kindness too.

Always appreciated it.

Mimi smiled faintly before opening her notes app again.

Then typed:

Some people borrow your hoodie and accidentally take a piece of your heart with it too.

She stared at the sentence for a second.

Then immediately added:

That sounded disgustingly emotional.

Still true though.

Chapter Twenty

When Kiye Gets Jealous ☁️💧

Kiye wasn’t usually a jealous person.

At least... not obviously.

She was friendly with everyone.

Talked to everyone.

Collected acquaintances like souvenirs.

But every once in a while, Mimi noticed something strange.

A shift.

Tiny.

Subtle.

Still noticeable.

Especially whenever someone else got too much of Mimi’s attention.

—

It started during art class.

The teacher rearranged seating plans temporarily, which meant Mimi ended up beside a girl named Alina for the afternoon project.

Alina was nice enough.

Funny too.

They spent most of the lesson laughing quietly while painting terrible landscapes and complaining about school.

Normal interaction.

Completely harmless.

Still, when class ended, Kiye appeared beside Mimi almost immediately.

“You replaced me.”

Mimi blinked. “What?”

Kiye crossed her arms dramatically.

“You laughed at someone else’s jokes.”

“That sounds slightly possessive.”

“It *is* possessive.”

Mimi laughed softly while packing her bag.

“You’re insane.”

“And suffering.”

Across the room, Naomi looked up briefly.

“She’s jealous.”

“I AM NOT.”

Silence.

Then Maja whispered loudly:

“That sounded guilty.”

Chaos immediately followed.

—

The thing about Kiye was that her jealousy never came out mean.

Just clingier.

More dramatic.

More attached.

The entire next day she practically stayed glued beside Mimi.

At lunch:

“You’re sitting with me.”

“Where else would I sit?”

“Good answer.”

In the hallway:

“Walk faster.”

“You walk like you’re being hunted.”

“Maybe I am.”

During maths:

“If you abandon me for Alina again I’ll become tragic.”

Mimi physically laughed into her sleeve.

“You’ve spoken to her once.”

“That’s once too many.”

“You’re ridiculous.”

“Yet lovable.”

Unfortunately true.

—

Later after school, the group stopped near the park while everyone decided where to go next.

The sky glowed soft orange above them while cold wind moved through the trees.

Mimi stood talking to Naomi about homework when suddenly—

Kiye appeared beside her out of nowhere.

Then casually grabbed Mimi’s hand.

Not dramatic.

Not attention-seeking.

Just natural.

Like she belonged there.

Mimi looked down slightly surprised.

Kiye avoided eye contact entirely.

Meanwhile Maja noticed instantly.

“Oh this is getting severe.”

“Shut up,” Kiye muttered.

Mahia grinned knowingly. “Someone’s territorial.”

“I hate all of you.”

Everyone laughed.

But secretly, warmth bloomed inside Mimi’s chest anyway.

Because despite all the teasing, there was something strangely comforting about being wanted that much.

—

That evening during the group call, the teasing continued mercilessly.

“Guys,” Maja announced dramatically, “today I witnessed Kiye emotionally fighting for custody over Mimi.”

“I hate this call.”

“You literally followed her around all day,” Naomi pointed out calmly.

“Because she’s my best friend.”

“A possessive best friend,” Mahia corrected.

Kiye groaned loudly while covering her face with a pillow.

Meanwhile Mimi sat there trying not to smile too hard.

Because honestly?

Kiye being jealous was weirdly adorable.

Not controlling.

Not cruel.

Just soft reassurance hidden underneath dramatic behaviour.

Like:

You still choose me, right?

And the answer was always yes.

—

Around midnight, after everyone else left the call, Kiye finally admitted it.

“Okay maybe I was slightly jealous.”

Mimi grinned instantly. “Slightly?”

“Don’t make this worse for me.”

“You’re clingy.”

“You love it.”

Dangerously true again.

Mimi lay across her bed smiling at the ceiling while Kiye’s voice crackled softly through headphones.

Then quieter, more honest this time, Kiye admitted:

“I just don’t like feeling replaceable.”

The sentence softened everything immediately.

Mimi’s smile faded into something gentler.

Because suddenly it wasn’t funny anymore.

Just vulnerable.

“You’re not replaceable,” Mimi said quietly.

Silence filled the call for a second.

Then Kiye laughed weakly.

“You answered too fast.”

“Because it’s obvious.”

Another pause.

Then softer:

“You promise?”

The question settled directly inside Mimi’s chest.

Because underneath all Kiye’s teasing and dramatics, there was still softness there.

Still fear.

Still the quiet human need to be chosen.

And maybe everyone wanted that secretly.

Someone who stayed.

“I promise,” Mimi whispered.

The silence afterward felt warm somehow.

Safe.

Then eventually Kiye ruined the emotional atmosphere completely by saying:

“Okay good because if you replaced me I’d haunt your future friendships forever.”

Mimi burst out laughing instantly.

“There she is.”

“Obviously.”

—

Before sleeping that night, Mimi opened her notes app again.

Then typed slowly:

Sometimes jealousy is just another way of asking:

‘Do I still matter to you?’

After a moment, she added:

Kiye never has to ask that question.

She’s already woven into every important part of my life.

Mimi reread the words quietly beneath dim fairy lights.

And somewhere in another house, Kiye was probably still pretending she hadn’t been jealous at all.

Chapter Twenty-One

The Notes App Confessions 🌙

Mimi started writing about Kiye without meaning to.

At first it was harmless.

Tiny sentences.

Random observations.

Funny things Kiye said during class.

But eventually the notes app on her phone became full of thoughts she never said out loud.

Not secrets exactly.

Just feelings too soft to explain properly in conversation.

—

“You’re always typing something,” Kiye noticed one afternoon.

Mimi locked her phone instantly.

“That’s private.”

“Oh my days,” Maja gasped dramatically from across the lunch table. “She’s journaling about us.”

“No she’s DEFINITELY journaling about Kiye specifically,” Mahia corrected.

Kiye looked delighted immediately.

“You have thoughts about me?”

“Horribly many,” Naomi muttered under her breath.

Everyone laughed.

Meanwhile Mimi sat there trying not to expose herself accidentally.

Because unfortunately... they weren’t wrong.

—

The notes started appearing naturally after certain moments.

Like:

Kiye laughs with her whole body.

Or:

She makes people feel included without even trying.

Or sometimes just random things:

Today Kiye stole my pen and called it “shared resources.”

Tiny observations.

Pieces of ordinary days preserved before they disappeared.

Mimi didn't even know why she wrote them down half the time.
Maybe because some moments felt too important to trust entirely to memory.
—

One rainy evening, Mimi lay across her bed while music played softly through headphones.
Her room glowed dimly beneath fairy lights.
Outside, rain tapped gently against the windows.
And naturally, somehow, her thoughts drifted toward Kiye again.
Toward the way she remembered small details.
The way she checked on people quietly.
The way she made difficult days feel survivable without even realizing it.
Mimi opened her notes app slowly.

Then typed:
I think Kiye loves people in the gentlest way possible.
She stared at the sentence for a moment.
Then added:
Like everyone deserves softness automatically.
Something about that felt painfully true.
—

The dangerous thing about writing thoughts down was that they became real afterward.
Undeniable.
Because once feelings existed in words, pretending they weren't important became impossible.
And lately Mimi's notes app looked dangerously full of Kiye-shaped feelings.
Platonic feelings.
Friendship feelings.
Still overwhelming somehow.
—

At school the next day, Kiye flopped dramatically into the seat beside her.
"I'm exhausted."
"You say that every morning."
"Because mornings are emotionally harmful."
Mimi laughed softly while opening her notebook.
Then suddenly Kiye narrowed her eyes suspiciously.
"You wrote about me again didn't you?"
"What?"
"I can tell."
"That's terrifying."
Kiye grinned proudly.
"You get this specific smile after I do something you'll definitely save in your little notes app."
Mimi froze slightly.

Because somehow...

Kiye was right.

Again.

"You know me too well," Mimi admitted weakly.

"Obviously."

Then softer:

"That's my job."

The sentence settled warmly inside Mimi's chest.

Because Kiye said affectionate things so casually sometimes.

Like caring deeply was the easiest thing in the world.

—

Later during free period, everyone sat scattered around the library pretending to revise.

Maja doodled instead.

Mahia listened to music.

Naomi actually worked because someone in the group had to.

Meanwhile Kiye rested her chin dramatically on Mimi's shoulder.

"What are you writing now?"

"Homework."

"Liar."

Mimi laughed quietly.

Then before she could react properly, Kiye snatched her phone off the table.

"Kiye—"

Too late.

Kiye opened the notes app immediately.

Mimi's soul physically left her body.

"Oh my DAYS," Kiye whispered dramatically.

Mimi covered her face instantly.

"Give it back."

But instead of teasing her immediately, Kiye went strangely quiet reading.

Then softer:

Kiye notices sadness like it personally offends her.

Another note:

She makes ordinary days feel important.

And another:

I hope she never doubts how loved she is.

The room suddenly felt too warm.

Too bright.

Mimi wanted to disappear completely.

But when she finally looked up, Kiye wasn't laughing.

She looked emotional.

“Oh,” she whispered quietly.

Mimi blinked.

“What?”

Kiye looked down at the phone again.

Then back at her.

“These are really sweet.”

The sincerity in her voice made Mimi’s chest ache instantly.

Because she expected embarrassment.

Teasing.

Dramatics.

Instead Kiye just looked... touched.

“You weren’t supposed to read those,” Mimi mumbled.

“I’m kinda glad I did.”

For a second neither of them spoke.

The library buzzed softly around them while rain streaked against windows outside.

Then quietly, Kiye handed the phone back.

“You write about people like you’re scared to lose them.”

The sentence hit harder than Mimi expected.

Because maybe there was truth inside it.

Maybe preserving moments was her way of holding onto them a little longer.

—

That night, after the group call finally ended, Mimi opened her notes app again.

Then paused.

Because now Kiye had seen pieces of it.

Pieces of how deeply Mimi cared.

And strangely?

That didn’t feel embarrassing anymore.

It felt honest.

So slowly, beneath dim fairy lights, Mimi typed one final note before sleeping:

Today Kiye read the way I write about her.

Then after a second:

She didn’t laugh.

She just loved me back gently for it.

And somehow that felt like one of the softest things that had happened between them yet.

Chapter Twenty-Two

The Almost Fight ⚡

The first time Mimi and Kiye argued properly, it felt wrong immediately.

Not dramatic movie wrong.

Just... unsettling.

Like seeing something fragile crack slightly.

—

It started over something stupid.

Which somehow made it worse.

The group had planned to meet after school at the shopping centre.

Simple plan.

Nothing complicated.

But throughout the day, Kiye kept disappearing with another group of classmates for some event practice thing.

Normally Mimi wouldn't have cared.

Except every time she looked up, Kiye barely acknowledged her before rushing off again.

No "I'll be back."

No usual smile.

Nothing.

Tiny thing.

Still enough to hurt a little.

—

By lunch, the feeling had settled uncomfortably inside Mimi's chest.

Not jealousy exactly.

Just the strange sadness of suddenly feeling unimportant to someone who usually made you feel deeply seen.

Kiye finally sat beside her halfway through lunch looking exhausted.

"Today's been so chaotic."

Mimi only nodded slightly.

Kiye blinked.

"You okay?"

"Yeah."

Too quick.

Too automatic.

The exact same tone Kiye used whenever *she* wasn't okay.

And unfortunately, Kiye noticed immediately.

"You're upset."

"I'm literally fine."

Maja looked between them slowly.

"Oh no."

Naomi sighed. "Here we go."

—

The conversation should've ended there.

Probably would've.

Except Kiye kept pushing gently.

“What happened?”

“Nothing.”

“Mimi.”

The softness in her voice somehow made the feeling worse instead of better.

Because suddenly Mimi felt stupid for even being hurt at all.

“It doesn’t matter.”

Kiye frowned slightly now.

“Clearly it does.”

Silence.

Heavy.

Uncomfortable.

Then finally Mimi muttered quietly:

“You’ve barely spoken to me all day.”

The table went completely silent.

Mahia stopped eating.

Maja looked emotionally invested already.

Aaliyah suddenly became very interested in her drink.

Kiye blinked.

“What?”

“You just keep disappearing.”

“I told you I had practice stuff.”

“I know.”

The problem was Mimi *did* know.

Which made her feelings feel irrational and embarrassing.

But hurt feelings rarely cared about logic.

—

Kiye stared at her for a second.

Then quietly:

“You know I’m not ignoring you on purpose, right?”

“I didn’t say you were.”

“But you’re acting like I did something terrible.”

The sentence landed harder than Kiye meant it to.

Mimi immediately looked away.

Because suddenly the whole situation felt awful.

“I’m not doing this,” she muttered softly before standing up.

“Mimi wait—”

But she was already walking away.

—

The rest of the afternoon felt wrong.

Painfully wrong.

No messages from Kiye.

No usual jokes.

No tiny check-ins.

Just silence.

And somehow silence from Kiye felt louder than anything else.

—

After school, rain poured heavily outside again.

Most students crowded near exits waiting for it to calm down.

Mimi stood near the back alone pretending to scroll through her phone.

Then footsteps approached carefully beside her.

Kiye.

For a second neither of them spoke.

Finally Kiye sighed quietly.

“I hate when we’re weird with each other.”

Mimi’s chest tightened instantly.

Because same.

Very much same.

Rain hammered softly against windows nearby while hallway noise blurred around them.

Then Kiye spoke again.

“I’m sorry if I made you feel ignored.”

The honesty in her voice immediately dissolved half the hurt inside Mimi’s chest.

Still, she looked down quietly.

“I know you didn’t mean to.”

“Then why didn’t you just tell me properly?”

Mimi swallowed hard.

Because honestly?

She didn’t know.

Maybe because caring deeply always made vulnerability embarrassing sometimes.

“I didn’t wanna sound clingy,” she admitted softly.

Kiye’s expression changed instantly.

Softened.

“Oh.”

Then, quieter:

“Mimi... you never have to act less important to avoid being ‘too much’ for me.”

The sentence hit directly inside her chest.

Warm.

Gentle.

Careful.

And suddenly all the sadness from earlier felt smaller.

—

Kiye stepped slightly closer now.

“I was busy today,” she admitted, “but I still thought about you literally the whole time.”

Mimi laughed weakly through lingering embarrassment.

“That’s disgustingly emotional.”

“I learned from you.”

Finally, finally, the tension cracked.

Soft laughter replacing heaviness.

Normal again.

Warm again.

Then Kiye frowned suddenly.

“Also you walking away dramatically was rude.”

“You accused me of acting like you committed crimes.”

“Because you looked deeply betrayed.”

“I was deeply betrayed.”

Kiye burst out laughing properly at that.

“There she is.”

Mimi smiled despite herself.

Because somehow even their arguments ended gently.

Not perfect.

Not painless.

But honest.

—

Eventually the rain softened enough for them to walk home together.

The group followed behind arguing loudly about something irrelevant again.

Normal chaos restored.

Kiye walked beside Mimi quietly for a while before bumping her shoulder lightly.

“You know what’s scary?”

“What?”

“The idea of us actually falling out one day.”

The sentence settled heavily between them.

Because after today, Mimi realized something too:

When someone became part of your comfort, even small distance hurt.

“We won’t,” Mimi said softly.

Kiye looked over.

“You sound sure.”

“I am.”

For a second Kiye just smiled quietly.

Then reached over absentmindedly hooking her pinky briefly with Mimi’s.

Tiny thing.

Still enough to say:

We’re okay again.

—

That night, Mimi opened her notes app one more time before sleeping.

Then typed:

I think real friendship is caring enough to fix things before pride ruins them.

After a pause, she added:

Even our arguments feel soft somehow.

Like neither of us knows how to stop choosing the other.

And honestly?

Maybe that was the most important part.

Chapter Twenty-Three

The Birthday Countdown Begins 🎂

Exactly thirty days before Kiye’s birthday, Mimi started panicking internally.

Not visibly.

Externally she acted completely normal.

But internally?

Complete emotional disaster.

Because how were you supposed to create a gift big enough for someone who had quietly become such an important part of your life?

—

“It’s just a birthday,” Naomi said calmly one afternoon.

“It is NOT just a birthday,” Mimi replied immediately.

Around the lunch table, everyone looked deeply concerned by her level of stress.

Mahia blinked. “You look like you’re planning a royal ceremony.”

Maja gasped dramatically. “WAIT are you making one of those emotional friendship gifts?”

Silence.

Mimi looked away instantly.

Everyone screamed.

“I KNEW IT,” Maja shouted.

Aaliyah laughed softly. “Poor Kiye’s gonna cry.”

“She cries over TikToks,” Naomi pointed out.

“True.”

Meanwhile Mimi sat there feeling both embarrassed and determined.

Because yes.

Maybe she *was* planning something emotional.

Something huge.

Something worthy of Kiye.

—

The problem was, every idea suddenly felt too small.

A playlist?

Already done.

Jewellery?

Not personal enough.

A letter?

Impossible to fit everything inside one letter anymore.

Because how could Mimi explain:

- the way Kiye made difficult days lighter,
- the way she noticed sadness immediately,
- the way her laugh felt like comfort now,
- the way she made ordinary moments unforgettable?

How did you wrap a friendship like that into a gift?

—

That evening, Mimi sat cross-legged on her bedroom floor surrounded by notebooks, printed photos, and messy ideas.

Fairy lights glowed softly around the room while rain whispered outside.

She stared down at an empty page for a long moment.

Then slowly wrote at the top:

For Kiye.

Simple.

Still enough to make her chest ache softly.

Because suddenly this project felt bigger than a birthday gift.

It felt like preserving a friendship.

Capturing this exact version of them before time moved again.

—

The next few days became filled with secret planning.

Mimi started saving everything quietly:

- screenshots of funny messages,
- blurry photos,
- tiny memories she never wanted forgotten,
- random quotes that sounded like Kiye somehow.

At school she acted normal.

Mostly.

Except apparently not normal enough.

“You’re suspicious lately,” Kiye announced during maths.

Mimi nearly dropped her pen.

“What?”

“You keep smiling at your phone.”

“That’s terrifyingly observant.”

“I know you.”

There it was again.

Those three words that somehow always affected Mimi emotionally.

Kiye narrowed her eyes playfully.

“You’re hiding something.”

“No I’m not.”

“Liar.”

Mimi laughed nervously while looking away.

Because technically...

She absolutely was hiding something.

An entire book, actually.

—

At lunch, the group started talking about birthdays again.

“What do you even want this year?” Mahia asked Kiye.

Kiye shrugged casually.

“I dunno. I just wanna spend it with people I love.”

The sentence hit Mimi right in the chest.

Because that was such a Kiye answer.

Not expensive things.

Not huge attention.

Just people.

Love.

Softness.

Maja immediately wiped fake tears away. “That was disgustingly wholesome.”

“I’m a wholesome person.”

“You threatened Naomi with violence yesterday,” Aaliyah reminded her.

“That was different.”

Everyone laughed.

Meanwhile Mimi stayed unusually quiet.

Because suddenly the pressure to make this birthday perfect felt even heavier.

Not because Kiye expected perfection.

But because she deserved effort.

—

Later that night, the group call lasted hours again.

At some point everyone started exposing old embarrassing photos.

Absolute chaos.

Maja screamed every thirty seconds.

Mahia nearly cried laughing.

Naomi threatened legal action repeatedly.

Then suddenly Kiye spoke softly through the laughter.

"You know what's kinda nice though?"

"What?" Mimi asked.

"That we found each other this young."

The room quieted slightly after that.

Kiye continued:

"Like... imagine never meeting your favourite people."

The sentence settled deeply inside Mimi's chest.

Because honestly?

She couldn't imagine it anymore.

A version of life without Kiye in it felt incomplete somehow.

And maybe that realization was exactly why this birthday mattered so much.

—

After the call ended, Mimi opened the notebook again.

Blank pages waited beneath warm fairy lights.

Slowly, carefully, she began writing.

Not just memories.

Feelings.

The kind too overwhelming for ordinary conversations.

Pages about:

- Kiye's laugh,
- shared playlists,
- matching bracelets,
- rainy afternoons,
- sleepovers,
- the way friendship could become a home.

And somewhere around page six, Mimi realized something terrifying.

This wasn't becoming a gift anymore.

It was becoming proof.

Proof that they existed like this once.

Fourteen and loud and soft and inseparable.

Before sleeping, Mimi opened her notes app one final time.

Then typed:

I think I'm trying to turn love into pages because I'm scared memories fade too easily.

After a second, she added:

Kiye deserves to be remembered beautifully.

And honestly?

Mimi planned to make sure she always would be.

Chapter Twenty-Four

The Scrapbook Project ✂️💖

By the second week of planning Kiye’s birthday gift, Mimi’s room looked like an explosion of memories.

Printed photos covered the floor.

Sticky notes filled entire notebook pages.

Half-finished playlists sat open on her laptop beside wrappers from snacks she forgot she’d eaten.

It was becoming slightly concerning.

—

“You’re actually losing your mind,” Naomi said flatly during their video call.

Mimi adjusted the camera dramatically toward the mess surrounding her.

“You don’t understand the vision.”

“No,” Naomi replied calmly, “I understand obsession.”

Mahia gasped suddenly. “WAIT show me the photos again.”

Mimi hesitated.

Because technically this entire project was supposed to stay secret.

But also... she was emotionally proud of it already.

So slowly she held one of the scrapbook pages up to the camera.

Mahia immediately screamed.

“Oh my DAYS.”

Even Naomi looked slightly emotional now.

The page was simple:

tiny printed memories,

song lyrics,

little handwritten captions beneath blurry photos.

One caption read:

The day Kiye laughed so hard she nearly fell off the bench.

Another:

Rainy afternoons somehow always feel softer with her around.

Mahia covered her mouth dramatically.

“She’s actually gonna sob.”

“That’s the goal,” Mimi admitted.

Naomi pointed accusingly. “Emotional terrorism.”

“Exactly.”

—

The scrapbook slowly became Mimi’s favourite part of the entire gift.

Because unlike normal presents, this one felt alive somehow.

Every page held pieces of them:

inside jokes,

late-night conversations,
tiny moments everyone else probably forgot already.
But Mimi remembered.
Of course she did.

—

One evening after school, Mimi sat cross-legged on her bed carefully cutting out tiny paper stars for decoration.
Music played softly nearby.
Then suddenly her phone buzzed.

Kiye:

what are u doing

Mimi panicked instantly.

Mimi:

nothing suspicious

Typing...

Kiye:

thats exactly what a suspicious person would say

Mimi laughed quietly to herself.
Because keeping secrets from Kiye was genuinely difficult.
Mostly because Kiye noticed everything.

—

The next day at lunch, Kiye narrowed her eyes immediately upon seeing Mimi.

"You're hiding something again."

"I'm literally eating chips."

"You have guilty energy."

Maja gasped dramatically. "GUILTY ENERGY."

"I'm surrounded by dramatic people," Mimi muttered.

"Answer the question," Kiye demanded.

"No."

Kiye leaned closer across the table.

"Is it about me?"

Mimi nearly choked.

Naomi sighed deeply. "You two are painful to observe."

Mahia looked delighted. "This is my favourite genre of friendship."

Meanwhile Mimi avoided eye contact entirely because unfortunately...

Yes.

Everything was about Kiye lately.

The scrapbook.

The playlists.

The handwritten pages.

The book itself.

All of it existed because Mimi loved her best friend enough to preserve her carefully.

—

That afternoon, while everyone else worked during free period, Mimi secretly wrote more scrapbook captions.

Tiny things.

Like:

Kiye notices sadness before it’s spoken aloud.

Or:

Some people feel like sunlight in human form.

And beneath one blurry photo of Kiye laughing:

The sound of her happiness fixes difficult days without trying.

Mimi stared at the words for a second afterward.

Then quickly closed the scrapbook before emotions became dangerous again.

—

Later that evening, the group gathered at Mahia’s house for movie night.

Nobody actually watched the movie properly.

Maja talked through half of it.

Naomi kept correcting plot details.

Aaliyah nearly fell asleep midway through.

Normal chaos.

Mimi sat beside Kiye sharing popcorn quietly while everyone argued about something irrelevant again.

Then suddenly Kiye rested her head briefly against Mimi’s shoulder.

Tiny thing.

Still enough to make Mimi’s chest ache softly.

“You’re comfy,” Kiye mumbled sleepily.

Mimi smiled faintly.

“You’re stealing my hoodie again.”

“Correct.”

A pause.

Then quietly:

“You’ve been weirdly soft lately.”

Mimi blinked slightly.

“What does that mean?”

“I dunno.”

Kiye smiled sleepily against her shoulder.

“You just keep looking at everyone like you’re trying to memorize us.”

The sentence hit too accurately.

Because that *was* exactly what Mimi had been doing.

Memorizing.

Preserving.

Holding onto moments before they disappeared.

And somehow Kiye noticed that too.

Of course she did.

—

That night after getting home, Mimi added another page to the scrapbook.

This one filled with tiny quotes everyone had said recently.

Messy.

Funny.

Warm.

At the bottom of the page, she wrote:

Maybe friendship is just collecting proof that you belonged to each other during certain parts of life.

Then after a second:

And maybe that’s why I’m trying so hard to save every moment with Kiye.

Mimi stared quietly at the nearly finished scrapbook beneath dim fairy lights.

The pages looked imperfect.

Handmade.

Loved.

Exactly how she wanted them.

And somewhere deep inside her chest, excitement mixed softly with fear.

Because soon Kiye would finally see how deeply she had been loved all along.

Chapter Twenty-Five

The Voice Notes She Keeps Replaying 🎧

Kiye sent voice notes the way other people breathed.

Constantly.

Random thoughts.

Chaotic storytelling.

Sudden singing at inappropriate hours.

Half the time they made no sense.

And somehow, Mimi saved almost all of them.

—

“Mimi.”

“Hm?”

“You’re suspiciously attached to your headphones lately.”

Mimi looked up from her phone slowly.

At lunch, everyone sat crowded around their usual table while sunlight spilled lazily through nearby windows.

“What does that even mean?”

Mahia gasped dramatically before Kiye could answer.

“WAIT. She’s replaying voice notes.”

Maja pointed instantly. “OH MY DAYS.”

Mimi nearly dropped her phone.

Naomi sighed like someone exhausted by ongoing nonsense.

“You all act like indie film characters.”

“It’s because we’re emotionally complex,” Kiye replied proudly.

“No,” Aaliyah corrected calmly, “you’re dramatic.”

Unfortunately true.

—

The thing was, Kiye’s voice notes felt strangely comforting.

Especially late at night.

Mimi replayed them while revising.

While cleaning her room.

While lying awake overthinking everything at 2AM.

Not because the conversations were important.

Most of them absolutely weren’t.

One voice note was literally Kiye ranting for two minutes about losing a sock.

Another was:

“If cereal counts as soup I’m actually leaving society.”

And somehow Mimi still listened to them repeatedly.

Because hearing Kiye’s voice made ordinary moments softer.

—

One rainy evening, Mimi sat cross-legged on her bedroom floor working on the scrapbook again.

Fairy lights glowed warmly around her room while music played quietly nearby.

Then her phone buzzed.

A new voice note from Kiye.

Mimi smiled automatically before pressing play.

Kiye’s tired voice filled the room softly:

“I’m so exhausted actually. School is evil. Also Mahia just sent me the ugliest sticker known to humanity and I think I’m emotionally damaged now...”

Mimi laughed quietly.

The voice note continued with random pointless stories after that.

Tiny details from Kiye’s day.

Thoughts nobody else would probably care about.

But Mimi cared.

Always.

Toward the end of the message, Kiye suddenly went quieter.

“Also I miss you. Which is dramatic because I literally saw you today but whatever.”

Mimi’s chest tightened softly.

Then immediately afterward:

“Okay bye before I become emotional.”

The voice note ended there.

Mimi replayed it twice anyway.

—

The next day during free period, Kiye dropped dramatically into the seat beside her.

“I sent you a masterpiece last night.”

“You sent me a three-minute crisis about socks.”

“It was vulnerable.”

Mimi laughed softly.

Then without thinking, she admitted:

“I replay your voice notes sometimes.”

Silence.

Maja slowly turned around from the table behind them.

“Oh this is severe.”

Mahia clutched her chest dramatically.

“That’s actually adorable.”

Meanwhile Kiye stared at Mimi looking weirdly emotional.

“You do?”

Mimi instantly regretted speaking.

“Well. Sometimes.”

Kiye looked genuinely touched by that.

Which somehow made it even more embarrassing.

“That’s kinda sweet,” she admitted quietly.

Naomi looked up briefly.

“Congratulations. You’ve all become unbearable.”

—

Later that afternoon, the group walked slowly home together while cold wind moved through the streets around them.

Maja argued loudly about music again.

Aaliyah threatened to abandon everyone.

Mahia filmed random clips for memories.

Meanwhile Kiye walked beside Mimi unusually quietly.

Then after a moment:

“Which voice note do you replay most?”

Mimi looked away immediately.

“I’m not answering that.”

Kiye gasped dramatically.

“YOU HAVE A FAVOURITE?”

“Stop making this worse.”

Kiye laughed brightly beside her.

The sound echoed warmly through the cold afternoon air.

Then softer, quieter this time:

“You know I keep your messages too, right?”

Mimi blinked slightly.

“What?”

“The long ones.”

Kiye shrugged casually, though her voice stayed gentle.

“Sometimes when I’m sad I reread them.”

Something inside Mimi’s chest melted instantly.

Because suddenly she realized something.

Maybe preserving each other had never been one-sided.

Maybe Kiye collected pieces of Mimi too.

—

That night, Mimi scrolled slowly through old voice notes before sleeping.

Tiny recordings of laughter and stories and ordinary moments.

Proof of friendship captured in sound.

One note made her laugh.

Another made her emotional unexpectedly.

Then she found one from weeks ago she’d almost forgotten about.

Kiye’s sleepy voice whispered softly through the speaker:

“You make life feel less lonely, by the way.”

Mimi stared quietly at the ceiling afterward.

Because sometimes Kiye said beautiful things so casually.

Like she didn’t realize the weight they carried.

Slowly, Mimi opened her notes app again.

Then typed:

I think voices become comforting when the person attached to them feels like home.

After a second, she added:

Kiye leaves pieces of herself everywhere.

Inside playlists. Photos. Voice notes. Memories.

Then finally:

Maybe that’s why she feels impossible to lose.

Chapter Twenty-Six

The Way Everyone Notices Them ☀️

At some point, people started noticing Mimi and Kiye before Mimi and Kiye noticed themselves.

Not romantically.

Just... as a pair.

The way certain best friends naturally became connected in people’s minds.

If someone saw Kiye, they automatically asked:

“Where’s Mimi?”

And if Mimi arrived somewhere alone:

“Wait, Kiye’s not with you?”

Somehow, without meaning to, they had become a unit.

—

“It’s actually concerning,” Naomi commented one afternoon.

The group sat outside near the field while warm sunlight spilled lazily across the grass.

“What is?” Mimi asked.

“You two.”

Kiye looked personally offended. “Excuse me?”

“You move like a synchronized friendship.”

Mahia burst out laughing instantly.

Maja pointed dramatically. “SHE’S RIGHT.”

“We do not.”

“You literally walked into school carrying matching drinks this morning,” Aaliyah reminded them.

Silence.

Then Kiye shrugged.

“Hydration is important.”

Everyone groaned.

—

The thing was, people noticed tiny things.

Like how Kiye always saved Mimi a seat automatically.

Or how Mimi looked for Kiye first in crowded hallways.

The way they shared earphones without asking.

The way one laughed whenever the other started laughing first.

Small habits.

Still obvious somehow.

—

During English, the teacher assigned partner work unexpectedly.

Before anyone could even react properly, Kiye and Mimi had already moved beside each other automatically.

The teacher paused.

Then smiled knowingly.

“Well, that was the fastest partnership decision I’ve seen all term.”

The classroom laughed lightly.

Mimi felt warmth creep into her face immediately.

Beside her, Kiye grinned proudly.

“We’re efficient.”

“No,” Naomi muttered from nearby, “you’re attached at the hip.”

Unfortunately... maybe slightly true.

—

Later during lunch, Mahia scrolled through old photos on her phone suddenly.

“Oh my days wait.”

Everyone leaned closer instantly.

The photos were from random school days over the past few months:

blurry cafeteria pictures,

group selfies,

park afternoons.

And somehow, in almost every single one, Mimi and Kiye stood beside each other.

Not intentionally posing.

Just naturally gravitating together.

Maja gasped dramatically.

“You guys literally orbit each other.”

“That sounds scientific,” Kiye said proudly.

“That’s not the point,” Naomi sighed.

Mimi stared quietly at the photos.

Because honestly?

She hadn’t realized how constant Kiye had become in her life until now.

Like background music always playing softly somewhere nearby.

Comforting.

Familiar.

Important.

—

That evening, the group gathered at the park again while sunset painted everything gold.

Maja attempted taking “cinematic” photos and failed horribly.

Mahia filmed aesthetic videos.

Aaliyah sat on the bench questioning all her life choices.

Meanwhile Mimi wandered slightly away from the group looking at the sky.

A few seconds later, footsteps approached beside her automatically.

Kiye.

Of course.

Neither of them even acknowledged it anymore.

“You disappeared,” Kiye said softly.

“You followed me.”

“Correct.”

Mimi laughed quietly.

Then both of them stood there side by side watching clouds drift slowly overhead.

Comfortable silence.

Easy silence.
The kind built over months of knowing someone deeply.
Then suddenly, behind them:
“AWW.”

Both turned instantly.
Mahia stood there grinning.
Maja looked emotionally invested already.
Naomi looked exhausted.
“You two literally move like magnets,” Mahia accused.

“We were just standing here.”
“TOGETHER,” Maja yelled dramatically.
Kiye laughed while throwing a leaf at them.
“You’re all deeply annoying.”

—
Later that night, Mimi thought about it more than she expected to.
The idea of being associated so closely with someone else.
Normally it would’ve scared her.
But with Kiye?
It felt natural.
Like somehow they had slowly become woven into each other’s daily lives without realizing it.
And maybe that was what deep friendship looked like sometimes.
Not grand gestures constantly.
Just consistency.
Showing up.
Sitting together.
Walking beside each other so often it became instinct.

—
Around midnight, Mimi’s phone buzzed.
Kiye:
mahia just called us soul sisters im actually crying
Mimi laughed immediately.

Mimi:
she’s dramatic
Typing...

Kiye:
lowkey she’s not wrong tho
Mimi stared at the message quietly.
Then another arrived:
u feel familiar in a way most people dont

The sentence wrapped itself softly around Mimi’s chest.
Because somehow Kiye always found ways to describe friendship beautifully without even trying.

Mimi:
that was disgustingly emotional

Kiye:
learned from u x

Mimi smiled helplessly at the screen.
Then before sleeping, she opened her notes app one more time.
And typed:

I think some friendships slowly stop feeling separate.

After a second:
Like two lives naturally learning each other’s shape.

Then finally:
Maybe that’s why everyone notices us together before they notice us individually now.

Chapter Twenty-Seven

The Secret Group Chat 📱 ✨

Every friendship group eventually creates too many group chats.
It was inevitable.
There was the main chat.
The homework chat nobody used for homework.
The photo dump chat.
The emergency drama chat.
And then there was the secret one.
The one Kiye definitely wasn't supposed to know about.
—

The chat had started three weeks before Kiye's birthday.

Maja:
operation make kiye cry begins now

Mahia:
IN A GOOD WAY RIGHT??

Naomi:
please specify before this becomes concerning

Mimi:
IN A GOOD WAY 🥹

Aaliyah:
okay good because i was worried
And just like that, the secret planning officially began.
—

Every day the chat became more chaotic.

People shared:

- favourite memories of Kiye,
- photos she'd forgotten existed,
- funny quotes she'd said,
- reasons they loved her.

At one point Mahia sent a seven-paragraph message.

At another point Maja somehow wrote an entire poem at 1AM.

Nobody questioned it.

—

One evening Mimi sat on her bed scrolling through the messages.

Fairy lights glowed softly around her room.

The chat buzzed constantly.

Mahia:

remember when kiye spent twenty minutes helping me look for glasses that were literally on my head

Maja:

remember when she comforted me for an hour over something i cant even remember now

Naomi:

remember when she stayed awake helping all of us revise even though she was more tired than everyone else

Mimi smiled quietly.

Because reading everyone's memories felt like seeing Kiye through a hundred different windows.

Everyone loved her for slightly different reasons.

But somehow those reasons all connected.

Kindness.

Loyalty.

Warmth.

Kiye left pieces of herself everywhere.

—

The difficult part was keeping the secret.

Especially because Kiye was unbelievably nosy.

“You're hiding something.”

“No I'm not.”

“You smiled at your phone.”

“That proves nothing.”

“It proves everything.”

Mimi laughed nervously while locking her screen immediately.

Across the table, Naomi looked dangerously close to laughing.

Which didn't help.

—

A few days later, disaster nearly struck.

The group sat together during lunch when Mahia accidentally opened the secret chat instead of the main one.

Right in front of Kiye.

Everyone froze.

Mahia froze.

Even time itself seemed to freeze.

“What was that?” Kiye asked suspiciously.

“Nothing.”

“That was definitely something.”

“Literally nothing.”

“You're all acting weird.”

Maja immediately started fake coughing.

Naomi looked ready to leave the country.

Aaliyah buried her face in her hands.

Meanwhile Mimi felt approximately seventeen years leave her lifespan.

—

Somehow they survived.

Barely.

But afterward the secret chat exploded.

Mahia:

I ALMOST ENDED US

Naomi:

you nearly caused a national emergency

Maja:

i saw my life flash before my eyes

Mimi:

never do that again

Mahia:

understandable

—

As the birthday grew closer, the messages became softer.

More emotional.

People started sharing things they rarely said out loud.

One night, Naomi sent:

Kiye makes people feel important. That's probably her best quality.

Then Aaliyah wrote:

She notices when people are struggling before they ask for help.

And Mahia added:

She's one of the safest people I've ever met.

Mimi stared at the messages quietly.

Because they matched everything she had been writing for months.

The same kindness.

The same warmth.

It wasn't just Mimi who saw it.

Everyone did.

—

The night before the birthday week officially began, the secret chat stayed active far too late.

Nobody wanted to sleep.

Excitement buzzed through every message.

Plans.

Ideas.

Final preparations.

Then suddenly Maja sent:

guys can we be serious for one second

A rare and terrifying event.

The chat immediately quieted.

Then another message appeared.

kiye is genuinely one of the best people i know

A pause.

Then:

i hope she knows that

For a moment nobody replied.

Because somehow the sentence felt too true.

Eventually, messages started appearing one by one.

Mahia:

me too

Naomi:

same

Aaliyah:

definitely

Mimi looked at the screen for a long moment.

Then finally typed:

we'll make sure she knows

The chat filled with heart emojis immediately afterward.

—

Later that night, while the rest of the world slept, Mimi opened her notes app again.

Then typed:

It's strange seeing someone through the eyes of everyone who loves them.

After a moment, she added:

Every memory says something different.

But together they all tell the same story.

Then finally:

Kiye has no idea how many people carry pieces of her kindness with them.

Mimi smiled softly at the words.

Because soon, very soon, Kiye was going to find out. 🎂💕

Chapter Twenty-Eight

One Week Left 🎈

Seven days.

That was all that remained until Kiye’s birthday.

Seven days until the scrapbook was given.

Seven days until the letters were read.

Seven days until Mimi finally handed over months of memories she had been carefully collecting.

And honestly?

She was terrified.

—

“You look stressed.”

Mimi looked up from her lunch tray.

Across from her, Kiye was watching her suspiciously.

“I’m not stressed.”

“You just stirred your drink for three straight minutes.”

“That proves nothing.”

“It proves emotional instability.”

Mimi laughed despite herself.

The truth was, every time she looked at Kiye lately, she had to stop herself from blurting out:

I made something for you.

Or:

You have absolutely no idea what's coming.

But somehow she managed to keep the secret.

Barely.

—

The birthday project was almost finished now.

The scrapbook sat safely hidden beneath Mimi's bed.

The playlists were complete.

The letters were folded carefully inside decorated envelopes.

And the book?

The book had become much bigger than she ever intended.

Pages filled with:

- memories,
- stories,
- playlists,
- inside jokes,
- little moments that most people would've forgotten.

Every chapter felt like a love letter to friendship.

A reminder that Kiye had mattered.

Deeply.

—

One afternoon after school, the group gathered at the park again.

The sky glowed pale gold above them while a cool breeze moved through the trees.

Maja lay dramatically across a bench.

Mahia filmed random clips for memories.

Naomi read a book while pretending not to listen to everyone.

Normal.

Comfortable.

The kind of ordinary day Mimi loved most.

Then suddenly Kiye sat down beside her.

Close enough for their shoulders to brush.

“Can I ask you something?”

Mimi blinked.

“Depends.”

“Dangerous answer.”

“What's the question?”

Kiye looked toward the sunset for a moment before answering.

“What’s your favourite memory of this year?”

The question hit Mimi like a truck.

Because how was she supposed to choose?

There were too many.

The sleepover.

The rainy afternoons.

The shared playlists.

The matching bracelets.

The voice notes.

The countless tiny moments in between.

Most of them included Kiye somehow.

“I don't know,” Mimi admitted softly.

Kiye smiled.

“That's a good sign.”

“What is?”

“If there are too many to choose from.”

Mimi looked over quietly.

And for a second, she wished she could tell Kiye everything.

How much effort had gone into preserving these memories.

How many nights she'd spent writing about them.

But not yet.

Soon.

Just not yet.

—

That evening, the secret group chat became active again.

Maja:

ONE WEEK PEOPLE

Mahia:

I'M SO EXCITED

Naomi:

please remain calm

Mahia:

NO

Aaliyah:

fair enough honestly

Mimi smiled while scrolling through the messages.

Everyone seemed just as excited as she was.

Maybe more.

Because the truth was, Kiye was loved by all of them.

Not just one person.

An entire group of people had quietly decided she deserved to feel appreciated.

And that felt beautiful somehow.

—

Three days later, disaster almost happened again.

Kiye nearly found the scrapbook.

Mimi had left her bag open during free period.

A single decorated page peeked out from between notebooks.

Just one.

But it was enough.

“Ooo what's that?”

Mimi's soul left her body instantly.

“Nothing.”

Kiye reached for it.

Mimi snatched it away at lightning speed.

Silence.

"...Mimi."

"No."

"You've never moved that fast in your life."

"Correct."

Kiye narrowed her eyes dramatically.

"You're hiding birthday things."

"I don't know what you're talking about."

"You absolutely do."

Maja immediately appeared out of nowhere.

"STOP INVESTIGATING."

"WHY?"

"JUST STOP."

Kiye looked deeply suspicious afterward.

But thankfully, she let it go.

For now.

—

By Friday, excitement sat permanently inside Mimi's chest.

Only two days left.

The gift was finished.

The scrapbook was finished.

Everything was ready.

And somehow that felt scarier than planning it.

Because soon Kiye would actually see it.

Would actually know.

Would actually understand how much she meant to everyone.

—

That night, Mimi couldn't sleep.

Rain tapped softly against her bedroom window.

Fairy lights glowed warmly across the room.

The finished scrapbook sat on her desk.

The book beside it.

Letters carefully tucked inside.

Proof of months of love and effort.

Proof of friendship.

Proof that Kiye mattered.

Mimi stared at everything for a long moment.

Then opened her notes app one final time before bed.

And typed:

One week ago this all felt impossible.

After a pause, she added:

Now it's real.

Then finally:

I hope Kiye sees herself the way the rest of us see her.

Mimi reread the words quietly.

Because that was what all of this had really been about from the start.

Not the gift.

Not the birthday.

Not even the surprise.

Just making sure one of the most loved people she knew finally understood how loved she truly was.   

Chapter Twenty-Nine

The Last Secret

Three days.

Just three days until Kiye's birthday.

And somehow, now that everything was finished, keeping the secret felt harder than ever.

—

“You are being weird.”

Kiye said it so casually that Mimi almost dropped her phone.

They were sitting together during lunch while everyone else argued over something completely unimportant.

“What do you mean?”

“I mean,” Kiye said, narrowing her eyes dramatically, “you keep looking at me like you're about to either cry or tell me a secret.”

Maja immediately burst out laughing.

Mahia nearly choked on her drink.

Naomi didn't even look up from her book.

“She's not wrong,” Naomi said calmly.

Traitor.

Absolute traitor.

—

The thing was, Kiye had become incredibly observant lately.

Or maybe she'd always been observant.

Maybe Mimi was just becoming worse at hiding things.

Every time Kiye smiled, Mimi thought about the scrapbook.

Every time Kiye laughed, Mimi remembered the book.

Every ordinary moment felt different now because Mimi knew something Kiye didn't.

Soon, all of this would belong to her.

All the memories.

All the pages.

All the proof.

—

That afternoon, during free period, Mimi sat alone in the library working on one final thing.

The dedication page.

The very first page of the book.

The page Kiye would read before anything else.

And somehow, despite writing thousands of words already, this felt like the hardest page.

Because how did you summarize someone like Kiye?

How did you explain what she meant to people?

After nearly twenty minutes, Mimi finally wrote:

For Kiye.

Thank you for every laugh, every memory, every late-night conversation, every tiny act of kindness you probably didn't even realize mattered.

This book is proof that you were here.

And proof that you were loved.

Mimi stared at the page afterward.

Then quickly closed the notebook before she became emotional in a public library.

—

Later that evening, the secret group chat became unusually serious.

No chaos.

No dramatic memes.

Just planning.

Naomi:

everyone ready?

Mahia:

physically yes emotionally no

Aaliyah:

same

Maja:

i genuinely think she's going to cry

Mimi smiled softly.

Then typed:

Mimi:

good

Almost immediately:

Mahia:

evil

Maja:

friendship terrorism

Naomi:

emotional warfare

Mimi laughed quietly to herself.

Maybe.

A little.

—

The next day felt strangely normal.

Which somehow made everything feel more important.

Because Mimi kept realizing:

This was one of the last ordinary days before the surprise.

One of the last days where Kiye had no idea what was waiting for her.

One of the last days before months of love became visible.

—

After school, the group walked together beneath a sky painted pink and gold by sunset.

The air felt warm.

The kind of evening people accidentally remembered years later.

Kiye walked beside Mimi, hands shoved into her hoodie pockets.

“You know what?”

“What?”

“This has been a really good year.”

The sentence caught Mimi off guard.

Because it sounded so simple.

But it carried so much.

“Yeah,” she said softly.

“It really has.”

Kiye smiled.

Then looked ahead toward the others laughing further up the path.

“I got lucky with you lot.”

Mimi felt her chest ache.

Because if Kiye only knew.

If she only knew how many pages existed because of that kindness.

How many people were secretly planning ways to tell her she mattered.

—

That night, sleep refused to come.

Again.

Mimi lay awake staring at the ceiling while fairy lights cast soft shadows across her room.

The scrapbook sat finished.

The letters sat finished.

The book sat finished.

Everything was ready.

Yet somehow her mind kept returning to one question:
What if it wasn't enough?
What if months of effort still couldn't explain how much Kiye meant to everyone?
What if words failed?
Eventually, Mimi sat up and opened her notes app.
Then slowly typed:
Maybe love isn't measured by whether words are perfect.
She paused.
Then continued:
Maybe it's measured by trying.
Another pause.
Finally:

And no matter what happens on her birthday, Kiye will know that we tried.

Mimi smiled softly at the screen.

Because that was true.

Every page.

Every photo.

Every playlist.

All of it was an attempt to say:

You mattered here.

You mattered to us.

And sometimes, that was the most important thing a person could hear.

—

Outside, rain began tapping gently against the windows again.

Inside, everything was ready.

The last secret was almost over.

And in just a few more days, Kiye would finally discover how many hearts she had quietly changed without even realizing it. 🤍 ✨ 📖

Chapter Thirty

The Night Before 🌙🎂

Tomorrow.

After months of planning, writing, collecting memories, and nearly exposing the surprise seventeen different times—

Tomorrow was finally Kiye's birthday.

And Mimi was absolutely not handling it well.

—

“You look like you're about to sit an exam.”

Mimi looked up from her phone.

The group was on a video call, everyone pretending to talk about normal things while secretly counting down to tomorrow.

“An exam would be easier,” Mimi muttered.

Mahia immediately laughed.

"That bad?"

"You don't understand."

"No," Naomi said, "we do understand. You've spent months creating an emotional weapon."

"Exactly."

Maja pointed dramatically at the camera.

"You wrote an entire BOOK."

"It wasn't supposed to become a book."

"That's literally what books are."

Fair point.

—

Meanwhile, Kiye sat in the call completely unaware.

Or at least mostly unaware.

She knew something was happening.

Everyone had become far too suspicious lately for her not to notice.

But she had no idea how big the surprise really was.

And that was somehow making Mimi even more nervous.

—

"Why is everyone staring at me?"

Kiye suddenly asked.

Instant panic.

Nobody answered immediately.

"See?" Kiye pointed. "That silence was suspicious."

"It wasn't."

"It was."

"It wasn't."

"It absolutely was."

Naomi muted herself because she was laughing too hard.

Traitor.

—

Eventually the conversation moved on.

Movies.

Music.

School.

Normal things.

But every so often Mimi caught herself looking at Kiye through the screen and thinking:

Tomorrow you'll know.

Tomorrow the scrapbook would belong to her.

Tomorrow the letters would be hers to keep.

Tomorrow all those hidden feelings would finally become visible.

The thought made Mimi's stomach flip.

—

The call ended around midnight.

One by one everyone left until finally the screen went dark.

And suddenly the reality hit.

Tomorrow.

Actually tomorrow.

—

Mimi got out of bed and crossed the room.

The scrapbook sat neatly on her desk.

The book beside it.

The playlist QR codes tucked carefully inside decorated envelopes.

Everything looked smaller than it had in her head somehow.

Months of effort reduced to a stack of pages.

And yet somehow those pages held entire worlds.

—

She opened the scrapbook slowly.

Just one last time.

The first photo.

The first memory.

The first page.

Every chapter of friendship preserved carefully between covers.

Sleepovers.

Rainy days.

Voice notes.

Matching bracelets.

Inside jokes.

Tiny moments most people would've forgotten.

But not Mimi.

Never Mimi.

—

Halfway through the scrapbook, she found a page that simply said:

Some people enter your life quietly.

Then somehow become one of the best parts of it.

Mimi stared at the words for a moment.

Because honestly?

That sentence explained almost everything.

—

Her phone buzzed suddenly.

A message.

From Kiye.

Kiye:

you awake

Mimi laughed immediately.

Mimi:

unfortunately

Typing...

Kiye:

same

Then:

Kiye:

i cant sleep

Mimi:

why

A pause.

Then the reply appeared.

Kiye:

just excited i guess

Mimi smiled softly.

Because even now, Kiye had no idea.

—

Another message arrived.

Kiye:

also

Typing...

Typing...

Typing...

Then finally:

Kiye:

thank you for being my best friend btw

Mimi froze.

Just slightly.

Because somehow the message arrived at exactly the wrong time.

Or maybe exactly the right one.

After everything she'd written.

After every memory she'd preserved.

After months of trying to explain what Kiye meant to her.

The message felt like a full circle moment.

—

Mimi:

always 

A simple reply.

Because anything longer would've made her cry.

—

A few minutes later:

Kiye:

goodnight mimi

Mimi:

goodnight kiye

And just like that, the conversation ended.

Ordinary.

Simple.

Perfect.

—

The house grew quiet.

Rain tapped softly against the windows.

Fairy lights glowed warmly across the room.

And for the first time all night, Mimi felt calm.

Because maybe she didn't need the perfect words.

Maybe the scrapbook didn't need to be perfect.

Maybe the book didn't need to be perfect.

Because none of it existed to impress Kiye.

It existed because she was loved.

And that truth had been sitting quietly inside every page from the beginning.

—

Before going to sleep, Mimi opened her notes app one final time.

One final note before the birthday arrived.

She typed slowly:

Tomorrow the secret ends.

Then:

Tomorrow Kiye sees herself through our eyes.

And finally:

I hope she sees what we've always seen.

A girl worth writing hundreds of pages about.

Mimi stared at the words for a moment.

Then locked her phone.

Outside, the rain continued softly.

Inside, everything was ready.

And somewhere in another house, Kiye was falling asleep on the last night before she discovered just how deeply she was loved. 🤍📖🎂✨

Chapter Thirty-One

The Morning of Fourteen 🌅🎈

The morning of Kiye's birthday arrived far too quickly.

One moment it was the night before.

The next, sunlight was slipping through Mimi's curtains and her phone was vibrating nonstop on her bedside table.

The group chat.

Of course.

—

Maja:

WAKE UP PEOPLE IT'S KIYE DAY

Mahia:

HAPPY BIRTHDAY EVEEEEE

Naomi:

it is 7:03 in the morning

Aaliyah:

and somehow maja is already shouting

Maja:

BECAUSE IT'S IMPORTANT

Mimi smiled into her pillow.

The excitement felt real now.

Today wasn't a countdown anymore.

Today was the day.

—

She got ready faster than usual.

Not because she was late.

Because she was nervous.

Every movement felt important somehow.

Every minute brought her closer to the moment Kiye would finally receive everything.

The scrapbook.

The letters.

The memories.

The book.

Months of love wrapped into pages.

—

When Mimi arrived at school, she spotted Kiye almost immediately.

Of course she did.

Kiye stood near the entrance surrounded by people wishing her happy birthday.

Laughing.

Smiling.

Looking happier than the sunrise itself.

And somehow, seeing that smile made all the nerves worth it.

—

The moment Kiye noticed her, her face lit up.

“MIMI!”

Before Mimi could even react, Kiye was already walking toward her.

“Happy birthday,” Mimi said, smiling.

“Thank you.”

Kiye grinned.

Then immediately pointed accusingly.

“You still have suspicious energy.”

Mimi burst out laughing.

“It's your birthday and you're investigating me?”

“Correct.”

“Unbelievable.”

“Thank you.”

—

The entire morning passed in a blur.

Teachers wished Kiye happy birthday.

Friends gave her cards.

People stopped her in hallways.

The group spent half the day teasing her mercilessly.

Normal birthday things.

But underneath all of it, Mimi carried a secret.

A secret hidden inside a carefully packed bag.

And every hour felt longer than the last.

—

At lunch, the group crowded around their usual table.

Maja had somehow acquired birthday decorations from nowhere.

Mahia brought cupcakes.

Naomi claimed she wasn't participating while actively participating.

Aaliyah took photos of everything.

Chaos.

Beautiful chaos.

—

“This is excessive,” Kiye laughed.

“No,” Maja corrected, “this is friendship.”

“Terrifying friendship.”

“Even better.”

Everyone laughed.

And for a moment, Mimi simply watched.

Watched Kiye smiling.

Watched everyone celebrating her.

Watched the people she loved gathered together around one table.

The moment felt important.

Like something she'd remember years later.

—

As lunch ended, Kiye stood up.

“Thank you guys.”

The table quieted slightly.

Kiye looked around at everyone.

At Maja.

Mahia.

Naomi.

Aaliyah.

Then Mimi.

And smiled.

A real smile.

The kind that reached her eyes.

“You lot genuinely make my life better.”

The sentence settled over the group softly.

Nobody joked immediately.

Nobody interrupted.

Because everyone knew she meant it.

—

Eventually Maja ruined the emotional atmosphere by fake crying dramatically.

“STOP BEING WHOLESOME.”

And just like that, everyone laughed again.

—

The rest of the school day crawled by.

Every lesson felt longer.

Every clock moved slower.

Because after school was when the real surprise would begin.

The moment everything changed.

The moment the pages stopped belonging to Mimi and started belonging to Kiye.

—

By the final bell, Mimi's stomach felt full of butterflies.

Students flooded out into the hallways.

Voices echoed everywhere.

And somehow, through all the noise, Mimi caught Kiye looking over at her.

“Ready?” Kiye asked.

The question made Mimi laugh.

Because Kiye had absolutely no idea what she was asking.

No idea what was waiting for her.

No idea how many memories had been gathered.

How many words had been written.

How many people had quietly come together because they loved her.

“Yeah,” Mimi said softly.

“I'm ready.”

And for the first time all day, she truly meant it.

The birthday had finally arrived.

And the surprise was only just beginning. 🍰💕✨📖

Chapter Thirty-Two

The Gift Table 📦💕

By the time everyone arrived at Maja's house after school, Mimi thought her heart might actually stop working.

Not from fear exactly.

From anticipation.

The living room had been transformed.

Balloons floated in the corners.

Fairy lights glowed warmly across the walls.

A handmade banner hung slightly crooked above the sofa because Maja had insisted she could do it herself.

She could not.

But somehow that made it better.

—

“This is actually insane.”

Kiye stood in the doorway staring around the room.

Everyone immediately looked away trying not to smile too hard.

Because the biggest surprise wasn't the decorations.

It was still waiting.

Hidden.

Patient.

—

Mahia handed Kiye a party hat.

Kiye looked personally offended.

“No.”

“Yes.”

“No.”

“Yes.”

Five minutes later she was wearing it.

Nobody was surprised.

—

The evening unfolded softly.

Pizza boxes.

Music.

Terrible dancing.

At one point Maja attempted to teach everyone a dance she'd seen online.

The attempt lasted approximately forty seconds before complete disaster.

Naomi sat on the sofa watching everyone with the expression of someone observing a nature documentary.

Aaliyah nearly cried laughing.

Normal friendship behaviour.

—

For a while, Mimi almost forgot about the gifts.

Almost.

Then she noticed the table.

The gift table.

Tucked beside the wall.

Covered in wrapping paper and ribbons and little cards.

And right in the middle—

The scrapbook.

The book.

Waiting.

—

The sight made her stomach flip.

Because suddenly everything felt real again.

Months of effort sitting quietly beneath fairy lights.

Waiting for Kiye.

—

Around seven o'clock, Maja clapped loudly.

“RIGHT.”

Everyone jumped.

“Gift time.”

Instant chaos.

Kiye groaned dramatically.

“Oh no.”

“Oh yes.”

“No.”

“Oh yes.”

There was absolutely no escaping.

—

One by one, Kiye opened presents.

Bracelets.

Cards.

Small thoughtful gifts.

Every single one received the same reaction:

A huge smile.

A hug.

A sincere thank you.

Because that was the thing about Kiye.

She treated every act of kindness like it mattered.

Because to her, it did.

—

As the pile of gifts got smaller, Mimi's nerves got bigger.

Much bigger.

Dangerously bigger.

The scrapbook and book sat untouched.

Still waiting.

—

Then finally.

Finally.

Only one gift remained.

The biggest one.

Mimi's.

The room seemed quieter somehow.

Not silent.

Just expectant.

Like everyone knew this moment was different.

—

Kiye looked down at the wrapped package.

Then back at Mimi.

“You look terrified.”

The room burst into laughter.
Because unfortunately, she wasn't wrong.
“I am.”
“Why?”
Mimi immediately looked away.
“No reason.”
“Suspicious.”
“Open it.”

—
Slowly, carefully, Kiye began unwrapping the gift.
The room watched.
Maja practically vibrated with excitement.
Mahia clutched a cushion dramatically.
Naomi looked calm.
But only on the outside.

—
The first thing Kiye saw was the scrapbook.
She froze.
Actually froze.
“What...”
Her voice came out barely above a whisper.
Then she opened it.

—
The room fell quiet.
Not because anyone was told to be quiet.
Because nobody wanted to interrupt.
Page after page.
Memory after memory.
Photos.
Captions.
Inside jokes.
Tiny moments carefully preserved forever.

—
Kiye turned each page more slowly than the last.
Sometimes smiling.
Sometimes laughing.
Sometimes covering her mouth.

—
Then she reached the page that said:

Some people feel like sunlight in human form.

Silence.

—

Then another:

Thank you for making ordinary days unforgettable.

More silence.

—

Then another.

And another.

And another.

Months of love laid out across paper.

Proof that people noticed.

Proof that people remembered.

Proof that she mattered.

—

The room stayed still.

Nobody rushed her.

Nobody interrupted.

Everyone simply let her read.

Let her feel it.

—

Finally, Kiye looked up.

Her eyes looked suspiciously shiny.

Very suspiciously.

Maja immediately pointed.

“SHE'S CRYING.”

“I'M NOT.”

“You literally are.”

“I'M NOT.”

She absolutely was.

—

Everyone laughed softly.

Even Kiye.

Though her voice sounded slightly wobbly now.

—

Then she noticed something else.

The book.

The one beneath the scrapbook.

—

Her smile faded into confusion.

Then disbelief.

Then complete shock.

—

“What is that?”

Mimi suddenly forgot how speaking worked.

“A thing.”

“A thing?”

“A book thing.”

“That explanation somehow made it worse.”

—

The room erupted into laughter.

But underneath it, anticipation buzzed quietly.

Because the scrapbook had only been the beginning.

And everyone knew it.

Especially Mimi.

Because she knew exactly what waited inside those pages.

Thirty-two chapters of friendship.

Thirty-two chapters of Kiye.

Thirty-two chapters of love, memories, laughter, and the people who adored her.

—

And as Kiye slowly reached for the book, Mimi realized something.

No matter what happened next—

The surprise had already worked.

Because for the first time all evening, Kiye looked exactly the way Mimi had hoped she would.

Not surprised.

Not overwhelmed.

Not emotional.

Just loved.

Completely, undeniably loved.    

Chapter Thirty-Three

The First Page

The room felt different now.

Quieter.

Softer.

Like everyone was holding their breath without realizing it.

The scrapbook sat open on Kiye's lap, pages filled with memories and laughter and proof that she had been loved in a hundred different ways.

But now there was something else.

The book.

—

Kiye looked down at it carefully.

Almost cautiously.

Like she was afraid touching it too quickly might somehow make it disappear.

“What is this?” she asked again, her voice quieter this time.

Mimi laughed nervously.

“A book.”

“Helpful.”

“Thank you.”

“You wrote a whole book?”

The room immediately erupted.

“THAT'S WHAT I'VE BEEN SAYING,” Maja shouted.

“Months,” Mahia informed dramatically. “She spent MONTHS doing this.”

Kiye looked between them.

Then back at the book.

Then back at Mimi.

“You actually wrote a whole book?”

Mimi felt her face grow warm.

“A little bit.”

“A LITTLE BIT?”

Naomi shook her head.

“The book is longer than some school assignments.”

“Much longer,” Aaliyah added.

“Dangerously longer,” Mahia agreed.

—

Kiye stared down at the cover again.

For a moment she didn't speak.

And suddenly, for the first time all evening, she looked overwhelmed.

Not in a bad way.

Just... stunned.

Like she couldn't quite understand why anyone would spend that much time on something for her.

—

Very carefully, she opened it.

The room immediately fell silent again.

—

The first page was simple.

No decorations.

No photos.

Just words.

Words Mimi had rewritten at least fourteen times.

Words that had somehow still never felt good enough.

—

Kiye began reading quietly.

For Kiye.

Thank you for every memory.

Thank you for every laugh that made difficult days easier.

Thank you for every late-night conversation, every shared playlist, every inside joke, every moment that became a story.

This book exists because you mattered.

Because people don't spend months writing about someone who didn't leave a mark on their life.

And you left marks everywhere.

In laughter.

In memories.

In friendships.

In hearts.

So this is for you.

Proof that you were here.

Proof that you were loved.

—

Silence.

Complete silence.

The kind of silence that only happened when words landed exactly where they were meant to.

—

Kiye blinked quickly.

Once.

Twice.

Then immediately looked at the ceiling.

Maja gasped.

“OH MY DAYS.”

“I'M FINE.”

“You looked at the ceiling.”

“I'M FINE.”

“That is literally the universal sign.”

Everyone laughed softly.

Even Kiye.

Though her voice sounded suspiciously emotional now.

—

Then she looked back down at the page.

And for a second, Mimi saw something she'd never forget.
Kiye smiling and trying very hard not to cry at the same time.

—

Slowly, Kiye turned the page.

Chapter One.

The beginning.

The very first memory.

The start of everything.

—

“You wrote all of this?”

Her voice came out almost as a whisper.

Mimi nodded.

The room suddenly felt too warm.

Too bright.

Too real.

—

“Why?”

The question surprised everyone.

Not because it was rude.

Because it sounded genuine.

Like Kiye truly didn't understand.

—

Mimi opened her mouth.

Then closed it again.

Because honestly?

There wasn't one answer.

There were hundreds.

The sleepovers.

The laughter.

The way Kiye noticed when people were hurting.

The way she remembered little things.

The way she made people feel important.

The way she had quietly become one of the best parts of so many lives.

How did you explain all of that?

—

Before Mimi could answer, Naomi spoke first.

“Because you're worth writing about.”

The room grew quiet again.

—

Then Mahia nodded.

“Very worth writing about.”

“Extremely worth writing about,” Aaliyah added.

“Ridiculously worth writing about,” Maja corrected.

—

Kiye looked down at the book.

Then at her friends.

Then at Mimi.

And suddenly her eyes looked shiny again.

—

“You guys are actually the worst.”

Everyone laughed.

“Why?” Mahia asked.

“Because now I'm emotional.”

“That sounds like a you problem.”

“Mahia.”

“Sorry.”

Not sorry at all.

—

The laughter softened the moment.

Just enough.

But the feeling stayed.

Warm.

Safe.

Important.

—

Kiye looked down at the book one more time.

Running her fingers gently across the pages.

Pages filled with stories she hadn't even read yet.

Memories she didn't know had been saved.

Moments she thought everyone else had forgotten.

—

Then very quietly, almost to herself, she whispered:

“I don't think anyone's ever done something like this for me before.”

The sentence settled heavily inside the room.

Not sad.

Just honest.

—

Mimi felt her chest ache softly.

Because that was exactly why she'd done it.

Not for praise.

Not for attention.

Just because sometimes people deserved to know they mattered.

And Kiye deserved that more than most.

—

For a moment, nobody spoke.

The fairy lights glowed softly above them.

Music played quietly somewhere in the background.

Outside, the evening sky was turning dark.

And inside, surrounded by the people who loved her most, Kiye held a book filled with proof.

Proof that she had changed lives.

Proof that she had left footprints in people's hearts.

Proof that she was loved.

—

Then Maja ruined the beautiful silence immediately.

“Right.”

Everyone looked over.

Maja stood dramatically from the sofa.

“Oh no,” Naomi muttered.

“Oh yes.”

Maja pointed toward Mimi.

“Now comes the speech.”

The room erupted instantly.

And Mimi's soul nearly left her body.

Chapter Thirty-Four

The Speech 🎂💕

“No.”

That was Mimi's immediate response.

Fast.

Firm.

Absolutely terrified.

“No.”

—

The room exploded with laughter.

Maja looked deeply offended.

“Yes.”

“No.”

“Yes.”

“No.”

“You literally wrote a whole book.”

“That’s different.”

“How?”

“I was alone when I wrote it.”

“Coward.”

—

Mimi buried her face in her hands immediately.

Because somehow writing thirty-four chapters about Kiye felt easier than speaking for thirty seconds in front of everyone.

Which was unfair.

Deeply unfair.

—

“Speech.”

“No.”

“Speech.”

“No.”

“Speech.”

“Please stop.”

The chanting only got louder.

Mahia joined immediately.

Aaliyah tried not to laugh.

Even Naomi looked suspiciously amused.

Traitors.

Every single one of them.

—

Then Mimi looked over at Kiye.

And immediately regretted it.

Because Kiye was smiling.

Not laughing.

Not teasing.

Just smiling softly.

Patiently.

Like she’d listen if Mimi wanted to speak.

Like she wouldn’t mind if she didn’t.

And somehow that made everything harder.

—

The room slowly quieted.

The fairy lights glowed softly above them.

The evening felt warm.

Safe.

Filled with people who loved each other.

And suddenly Mimi realized something.

Maybe this didn't need to be perfect.

Maybe it just needed to be honest.

—

She stood up slowly.

Immediately regretted it.

Then stood there awkwardly anyway.

—

“Okay.”

The room went quiet.

Much quieter than expected.

Even Maja stopped talking.

A historical event.

—

Mimi looked at Kiye.

Then looked down.

Then looked back up again.

Because if she didn't start now, she never would.

—

“Happy birthday.”

A few people smiled immediately.

Simple beginning.

Safe beginning.

—

“I spent ages trying to figure out what I wanted to say.”

She laughed softly.

“And apparently I wrote an entire book instead.”

The room laughed.

Even Kiye.

—

“But I think the reason I struggled is because it's really hard to explain what someone means to you when they've become part of so many important memories.”

The room grew quiet again.

—

Mimi glanced at Kiye.

Still smiling.

Still listening.

—
“You’re one of the kindest people I know.”

The words came easier now.

“You make people feel included without even trying.”

“You remember things that most people forget.”

“You check on people.”

“You notice when someone’s upset.”

“You care.”

—
Kiye immediately looked down.

Embarrassed.

Exactly as expected.

—
“And I don’t think you always realize how much that matters.”

Mimi continued softly.

“Because sometimes you do these little things and move on.”

“But the people around you remember them.”

The room felt completely still now.

—
“We remember them.”

Mimi smiled gently.

“Every single one of us.”

—
Mahia nodded immediately.

Aaliyah smiled.

Naomi looked down for a moment.

Even Maja looked emotional.

Which was honestly alarming.

—
“You make people feel important.”

Mimi’s voice softened.

“And that’s rare.”

“Really rare.”

—
For a second, Kiye blinked rapidly.
The same way she had when reading the book.

—
Then Mimi laughed quietly.
“Also you steal everyone’s hoodies.”

The room exploded.

Instantly.

—

“THAT IS TRUE,” Maja yelled.

“Justice for the hoodies,” Naomi agreed.

“I REGRET NOTHING,” Kiye defended.

The tension cracked.

Laughter filled the room again.

Warm laughter.

Comfortable laughter.

—

Then Mimi took a small breath.

Because there was one last thing she wanted to say.

The most important thing.

—

The room slowly settled again.

—

“I think...”

She paused.

Trying to find the right words.

—

“I think one of the best things that’s happened to me is meeting you.”

Silence.

Soft silence.

The kind that wrapped around a room instead of weighing it down.

—

“You’ve made my life happier.”

“You’ve made difficult days easier.”

“You’ve given me memories I know I’ll still be thinking about years from now.”

—

Kiye looked like she was trying very hard not to cry.

Very hard.

And failing slightly.

—

“So this book...”

Mimi glanced toward it.

“...is really just proof.”

“Proof that you mattered.”

“Proof that people noticed.”

“Proof that you’re loved.”

—

Her voice softened even further.

Almost a whisper now.

—

“And I hope whenever you feel lonely or insecure or forgotten...”

She smiled.

“...you can open it and remember that none of those things are true.”

—

The room was completely silent.

Nobody moved.

Nobody spoke.

—

Then finally:

“Happy fourteenth birthday, Kiye.”

Mimi smiled.

“And thank you for being my best friend.”



—

For one second, nobody said anything.

Then Maja started crying.

Actual tears.

—

“OH MY DAYS.”

“MAJA,” Naomi groaned.

“THAT WAS BEAUTIFUL.”

“You’re ruining the moment.”

“I KNOW.”

—

The room burst into laughter again.

Even through the tears.

Even through the emotions.

Because that was who they were.

A group of people who loved each other enough to cry.

And laugh.

Usually at the same time.

—

Meanwhile Kiye sat there holding the book against her chest.

Not speaking.

Just smiling.
The kind of smile that said more than words ever could.
And somehow, looking at that smile, Mimi knew something.
The speech had never needed to be perfect.
It just needed to be true.
And it was.

Chapter Thirty-Five

What Kiye Says Back  

For a few moments after Mimi sat back down, the room stayed quiet.
Not awkward quiet.
The kind of quiet that happened when everyone knew something important had just been said.
The kind that felt warm.
Safe.
Real.
—

Kiye still held the book against her chest.
Like letting go of it too quickly might somehow make the moment disappear.
Her eyes were still suspiciously shiny.
Very suspiciously shiny.
But nobody mentioned it.
Mostly because Maja had already cried enough for everyone.
—

“Okay.”
Kiye took a deep breath.
Then immediately laughed.
“Why am I nervous?”
“Because we emotionally attacked you,” Mahia answered.
“Fair.”
—

The room laughed softly.
And somehow that made it easier.
Easier to speak.
Easier to breathe.
Easier to say the things sitting inside her heart.
—

Kiye looked around the room.
At Maja.
Mahia.

Naomi.

Aaliyah.

Then finally Mimi.

—

“You guys are actually ridiculous.”

Maja gasped dramatically.

“That isn't a thank you.”

“It is where I come from.”

“It absolutely isn't.”

—

More laughter.

Then Kiye smiled.

A smaller smile.

A softer one.

—

“No, but seriously.”

The room quieted again.

And this time nobody interrupted.

—

“I don't think you realize how much this means to me.”

Her voice wasn't shaky.

Just honest.

The kind of honesty that made everyone listen a little closer.

—

“I keep trying to think of the right thing to say...”

She looked down at the scrapbook.

Then the book.

Then back up.

“...but every sentence feels too small.”

—

Mimi felt her chest tighten softly.

Because that was exactly how she had felt while writing it.

—

Kiye laughed quietly.

“Which is annoying.”

“Very annoying.”

“Extremely annoying.”

The group smiled.

—

Then her expression softened again.

—

“I think sometimes...”

She paused.

Searching for the words.

“I think sometimes I forget people see me.”

The room grew still.

—

“Not literally.”

Kiye laughed weakly.

“But I mean...”

She looked down.

“...I don't always think the things I do matter that much.”

—

Mahia's eyes immediately filled with tears again.

“Oh no.”

“Mahia,” Naomi warned.

“I'M TRYING.”

—

The room laughed softly.

But nobody looked away from Kiye.

—

“Like helping people.”

Kiye shrugged.

“Or checking on them.”

“Or remembering things.”

“I just do it.”

—

She glanced toward the scrapbook.

“And then today happened.”

The sentence landed gently.

Like a feather.

Like truth.

—

“And suddenly I'm looking through pages of memories I didn't know people remembered.”

Her voice grew quieter.

“Photos I forgot existed.”

“Conversations I barely remembered.”

“Moments I thought were normal.”

—

She smiled softly.

“But they weren't normal.”

A pause.

“They were important.”

—

Nobody spoke.

Because everyone knew she was right.

—

Then Kiye looked directly at Mimi.

And for a second, the rest of the room disappeared.

—

“You spent months making this.”

The words came out almost as a whisper.

“You wrote a whole book.”

“You collected memories.”

“You saved things I would've forgotten.”

—

Mimi felt tears prick unexpectedly behind her eyes.

Dangerous.

Very dangerous.

—

Then Kiye smiled.

The gentlest smile she'd worn all evening.

—

“Thank you.”

Simple words.

Still enough to make Mimi's heart ache.

—

“Thank you for noticing.”

Kiye's voice softened.

“Thank you for remembering.”

“And thank you for loving me enough to make something like this.”

—

The room was silent again.

The good kind.

The meaningful kind.

—

Then suddenly Kiye laughed.

—

“Also.”

Everyone looked up.

—

“You all need help.”

Immediate chaos.

—

“EXCUSE ME?” Maja shouted.

“You wrote poems.”

“I WAS MOVED.”

“Mahia wrote seven paragraphs.”

“I HAD FEELINGS.”

“You all secretly created an operation.”

“Correct,” Naomi said.

“AND NONE OF YOU TOLD ME.”

—

The room exploded with laughter.

The tension shattered instantly.

—

Kiye laughed so hard she had to wipe her eyes.

And somehow that made everyone else laugh harder too.

Because this was them.

Not perfect speeches.

Not movie moments.

Just love mixed with laughter.

Every single time.

—

Eventually the room settled again.

The music played softly in the background.

Fairy lights glowed overhead.

The evening felt warm and endless.

—

Then quietly, almost as an afterthought, Kiye looked at her friends and said:

“I hope you all know something too.”

The room stilled.

—

“You make my life better.”

No jokes.

No teasing.

Just truth.

—

“Every single one of you.”

She smiled.

“I don't think I'd be the same person without you.”

Mahia immediately started crying again.

—

“MAHIA.”

“I CAN'T HELP IT.”

—

Everyone laughed through their own emotions.

And somehow the moment became even more beautiful because of it.

—

Later that night, long after the presents were opened and the laughter had faded into quieter conversations, Mimi would remember this moment most clearly.

Not the speech.

Not the book.

Not even the scrapbook.

—

Just Kiye sitting beneath fairy lights.

Holding a book full of memories.

Looking around at the people who loved her.

And finally seeing herself the way they saw her.

Loved.

Completely.

Unconditionally.

Deeply.

—

And for Mimi, that made every page worth writing.

Chapter Thirty-Six

The Playlist Chapter 🎵💗

Some memories were written.

Some were photographed.

And some lived inside songs.

—

A few days after her birthday, Kiye finally reached Chapter Thirty-Six.

She was curled up beneath a blanket, fairy lights glowing softly around her room, the book resting open on her lap.

And across the top of the page, in neat handwriting, were the words:

For every memory that sounds like music.

—

Beneath it was a note from Mimi.

Some songs remind me of our friendship.

Some remind me of you.

Some remind me of birthdays, sleepovers, rainy afternoons, and all the little moments in between.

So here's a chapter made entirely of music.



Playlist One:

Songs That Feel Like Our Friendship

The songs that sound like laughter, late-night calls, and the feeling of belonging.

- **Best Friend** — Rex Orange County
- **We're Going To Be Friends** — The White Stripes
- **Count On Me** — Bruno Mars
- **Yellow** — Coldplay
- **Home** — Edward Sharpe & The Magnetic Zeros
- **Long Live** — Taylor Swift
- **You've Got A Friend In Me** — Randy Newman
- **Never Grow Up** — Taylor Swift
- **Good Old Days** — Macklemore & Kesha
- **Photograph** — Ed Sheeran

—

Underneath the playlist, Mimi had written:

If someone asked me what friendship sounds like, I'd probably hand them this playlist.

Playlist Two:

Songs That Remind Me Of Kiye

The playlist that somehow feels like sunshine, kindness, and warmth.

- **Golden** — Harry Styles
- **Beautiful Things** — Benson Boone
- **Sunflower** — Post Malone & Swae Lee
- **Best Part** — Daniel Caesar & H.E.R.
- **Sweet Creature** — Harry Styles
- **Bloom** — The Paper Kites
- **Golden Hour** — JVKE
- **You Are The Reason** — Calum Scott
- **Daylight** — Taylor Swift
- **Little Things** — One Direction

—

At the bottom:

You make ordinary days brighter.

This playlist felt appropriate.

Playlist Three:

For Your Fourteenth Birthday 🎂

The songs meant for growing up, celebrating, and remembering this year forever.

- **Birthday** — Katy Perry
- **22** — Taylor Swift (even though you're not 22)
- **Unwritten** — Natasha Bedingfield
- **Firework** — Katy Perry
- **Hall of Fame** — The Script
- **Good Time** — Owl City & Carly Rae Jepsen
- **On Top Of The World** — Imagine Dragons
- **Brave** — Sara Bareilles
- **A Million Dreams** — from *The Greatest Showman*
- **Happy** — Pharrell Williams

—

A note underneath read:

May fourteen be kind to you.

May it bring adventures, laughter, and memories worth writing about.

Playlist Four:

Songs About How Beautiful You Are 🌸

Not just beautiful on the outside.

Beautiful in the way you care.

Beautiful in the way you love people.

Beautiful in the way you exist.

- **Beautiful** — Christina Aguilera
- **What Makes You Beautiful** — One Direction
- **Pretty Girl** — Clairo
- **Dandelions** — Ruth B.
- **Lovely** — Billie Eilish & Khalid
- **Just The Way You Are** — Bruno Mars
- **Golden Hour** — JVKE
- **Ocean Eyes** — Billie Eilish
- **Teenage Dream** — Olivia Rodrigo
- **Invisible String** — Taylor Swift

—

Beneath it:

You have always been beautiful.

But the prettiest thing about you has never been the way you look.

It's the way you make people feel.

Playlist Five:

The Happy Songs Playlist ☀️

Songs for laughing until your stomach hurts.

Songs for dancing badly with your friends.

Songs for feeling alive.

- **Walking On Sunshine** — Katrina and the Waves
- **Shake It Off** — Taylor Swift
- **Can't Stop The Feeling!** — Justin Timberlake
- **Good Life** — OneRepublic
- **Pocketful of Sunshine** — Natasha Bedingfield
- **Dynamite** — BTS
- **Magic** — One Direction
- **Best Day Of My Life** — American Authors
- **Sunday Best** — Surfaces
- **I'm Still Standing** — Elton John

Playlist Six:

The Bittersweet Playlist 🌙

The songs for missing people while still loving them.

The songs for memories.

The songs for growing up.

- **The Night We Met** — Lord Huron
- **Youth** — Daughter
- **Slipping Through My Fingers** — ABBA
- **Ribs** — Lorde
- **Older** — Sasha Alex Sloan
- **Scott Street** — Phoebe Bridgers
- **Saturn** — Sleeping At Last
- **When We Were Young** — Adele
- **Vienna** — Billy Joel
- **You're Gonna Go Far** — Noah Kahan

—
Underneath, in smaller handwriting:

Not because we're growing apart.

But because one day we'll look back on this version of ourselves and miss her a little.

At the very end of the chapter was one final note.

No playlist.

No song titles.

Just words.

Thank you for being part of the soundtrack of my life.
Thank you for every shared earphone, every recommendation, every song that became a memory.
Years from now, certain songs will come on unexpectedly.
And I know they'll make me think of you.
I hope they do the same for you.

Love,
Mimi  

Chapter Thirty-Seven

Letters From Everyone

A few pages after the playlist chapter, Kiye found a divider page.
It was decorated with tiny doodled hearts, stars, and polaroid drawings.
Across the middle, in careful handwriting, were the words:

Letters From The People Who Love You

Kiye smiled immediately.
Then laughed.
Then prepared herself emotionally.
Because after thirty-six chapters, she had learned one thing:
Nothing in this book was emotionally safe.

—
At the top of the next page, Mimi had written:
One person can tell you that you're loved.
But hearing it from many people is a different kind of magic.
So I asked some of the people who care about you most to write something.
And, unsurprisingly, they had a lot to say.

A Letter From Maja

Dear Kiye,
Firstly, how dare you make me emotional.
Secondly, happy birthday.
You are genuinely one of the funniest, kindest, most caring people I've ever met.
Some of my favourite memories have you in them.
You make ordinary days feel exciting and difficult days feel easier.
Thank you for every laugh, every conversation, every ridiculous moment we've shared.
Please never stop being you.
Love,
Maja 

A Letter From Mahia

My Kiye,
I don't think you understand how much light you bring into people's lives.
You have this incredible ability to make people feel seen.
You check on people.
You care about people.
You remember things that matter.
And even when you're struggling yourself, you still somehow find room to be kind.
Thank you for every memory and every laugh.
I hope this year gives you as much happiness as you've given everyone around you.
Happy fourteenth birthday.
Love always,
Mahia 🧡

A Letter From Naomi 🌙

Dear Kiye,
I know everyone else is being emotional, so naturally I must continue the tradition.
You are one of the most genuine people I know.
What I admire most about you is that your kindness never feels performative.
You help people because you want to.
You listen because you care.
You show up because that's who you are.
Thank you for being a wonderful friend.
The world needs more people like you.
Love,
Naomi 💜

A Letter From Aaliyah 🌻

Happy Birthday, Kiye.
I feel incredibly lucky to know you.
Thank you for every conversation, every joke, every memory, and every moment of support.
You make people feel welcome.
You make people feel valued.
And that's a gift not everyone has.
I hope fourteen brings you beautiful things, exciting memories, and all the happiness you deserve.
Love,
Aaliyah 🧡

Kiye paused after reading the letters.
The pages blurred slightly.

A very suspicious development.

Very suspicious indeed.

—

Then she turned the page.

And froze.

Because there was one final letter.

Longer than the others.

Written in familiar handwriting.

—

A Letter From Mimi

Dear Kiye,

If you've made it this far through the book, congratulations.

You've survived thirty-six chapters.

Which is honestly impressive.

I don't know if there's a perfect way to end this.

I've spent months writing about our friendship and somehow it still doesn't feel like enough.

There are still memories I forgot to include.

Still moments I wish I had written down.

Still a thousand things I wish I could tell you.

—

Kiye smiled softly.

She already knew this sounded exactly like Mimi.

—

But if there's one thing I hope you take away from all of this, it's this:

You matter.

More than you know.

More than you realize.

More than you probably give yourself credit for.

—

The words felt familiar.

Because they echoed through almost every chapter.

—

You have made people laugh.

You have made people feel included.

You have helped people through difficult days.

You have become part of some of my favourite memories.

—

Kiye blinked rapidly.

Dangerously rapidly.

—

And one day, when we're older and life looks completely different,
I know I'll still look back on this friendship and smile.
Because knowing you has made my life better.

—

A tear landed on the page.
Just one.
Kiye immediately wiped it away.
As if nobody was watching.
Even though nobody was there.

—

Thank you for every memory.
Thank you for every laugh.
Thank you for being one of the most important people in my life.
And thank you for letting me call you my best friend.

—

Kiye took a shaky breath.
Then kept reading.

—

Happy fourteenth birthday.
I hope this year is kind to you.
I hope you never forget how loved you are.
And I hope whenever life feels difficult, you remember there is an entire group of people cheering for you.
Including me.
Always.



Love,
Mimi

—

For a long moment, Kiye just stared at the page.
The room around her quiet.
The fairy lights glowing softly.
The book open in her lap.

—

Then she smiled.
A real smile.
The kind that reached her eyes.
The kind built from gratitude and memories and love.

—

And quietly, to nobody in particular, she whispered:

“I'm keeping this forever.”

Because some gifts were temporary.

Some gifts faded.

Some gifts were forgotten.

But this one?

This one was made from friendship.

And friendship had a way of lasting.

Chapter Thirty-Eight

The Photos We Almost Forgot 📸💔

Some memories arrive with dramatic music.

Some arrive with life-changing speeches.

And some arrive as blurry photos taken at the worst possible moment.

—

When Kiye turned to Chapter Thirty-Eight, she immediately laughed.

Because the entire page was covered in terrible pictures.

Absolutely terrible.

—

At the top, Mimi had written:

Not every memory is perfect.

Thankfully, neither are we.

—

The first photo showed Maja mid-sneeze.

Not a graceful sneeze.

A catastrophic sneeze.

The kind that looked like it belonged in a history textbook.

Beneath it:

Maja threatened legal action after this photo was taken.

—

The next picture showed Mahia laughing so hard she was nearly falling off a bench.

The photo was blurry.

The horizon was crooked.

Nobody knew who took it.

—

The caption read:

Evidence that happiness is contagious.

—

Then came a photo of Naomi reading while complete chaos unfolded behind her.

Someone was running.

Someone was yelling.

Someone appeared to be holding a traffic cone.

—

Naomi remained completely unbothered.

—

The caption:

Some people create the chaos.

Others simply survive it.

—

Kiye laughed so hard she had to pause reading.

Because honestly?

Accurate.

Very accurate.

—

The next few pages were filled with moments nobody had planned to remember.

A blurry lunch table.

Half-finished conversations.

A badly lit group selfie.

Someone's shoe for some reason.

—

Tiny moments.

Ordinary moments.

The kind most people overlooked.

—

But Mimi hadn't.

—

Under one photo of everyone sitting together after school, she'd written:

Nothing important happened here.

And somehow it became one of my favourite memories.

—

Kiye stared at that caption for a long moment.

Because she understood exactly what it meant.

—

Not every important memory felt important while it was happening.

Sometimes the best moments were the ordinary ones.

The ones that slipped past unnoticed until later.

—

Then she turned the page.

And froze.

—

The next section was called:

Photos That Were Never Meant To Be Emotional

—

The first photo showed Kiye sitting on a park bench.

Nothing dramatic.

Nothing special.

She wasn't even looking at the camera.

—

She was laughing at something someone had said.

Head tilted back.

Completely unaware the photo was being taken.

—

Beneath it:

One of my favourite pictures of you.

Because you're not posing.

You're just happy.

—

Kiye swallowed hard.

—

The next photo showed the group walking home together.

Nobody facing the camera.

Nobody paying attention.

Just silhouettes against a sunset.

—

The caption:

I don't remember what we were talking about.

I only remember not wanting the walk to end.

—

Another page.

Another photo.

—

This one showed everyone crowded around a lunch table.

The picture wasn't good.

Half the faces were blurry.

Someone was blinking.

Someone was missing entirely.

—

Yet beneath it:

Proof that happiness doesn't always look perfect.

—

Kiye smiled softly.

Because none of the photos were perfect.

And somehow that made them more beautiful.

—

Near the end of the chapter was one final picture.

A photo Kiye didn't even remember being taken.

—

The entire group sat together on the grass.

Maja talking with her hands.

Mahia laughing.

Naomi pretending not to smile.

Aaliyah looking amused.

And Kiye in the middle of it all.

—

Just existing.

—

The caption underneath was longer than the others.

—

I almost didn't include this one.

Not because it's bad.

Because it's ordinary.

But then I realized something.

Most of the moments I treasure are ordinary.

The laughter.

The conversations.

The afternoons that didn't seem important at the time.

Maybe that's what friendship really is.

A collection of ordinary moments that become extraordinary because of who you're sharing them with.

—

Kiye read the paragraph twice.

Then a third time.

—

Because maybe that was the lesson hidden inside the entire book.

Not just this chapter.

All of it.

—

The best memories weren't always the biggest ones.

The speeches.

The surprises.

The birthdays.

—

Sometimes they were just:

A walk home.

A shared joke.

A lunch table.

A blurry photograph.

—

At the bottom of the final page, Mimi had written one last note.

—

One day we'll look at these photos and laugh.

Not because they're perfect.

But because they're ours.



—

Kiye closed the book for a moment.

Just for a moment.

Holding it against her chest again.

—

Because suddenly she understood something.

The book had never really been about a birthday.

Not completely.

—

It was about preserving a season of life.

A collection of people.

A friendship.

A feeling.

—

And maybe that was why it felt so special.

Because it wasn't trying to make the memories bigger than they were.

It was simply reminding her they mattered.

—

And they did.

Every single one of them.

Chapter Thirty-Nine

The Promise 🌙🤝💗

By the time Kiye reached the second-to-last chapter, it was late.

The house was quiet.

The birthday decorations had mostly been taken down.

The cake was gone.

The balloons were slowly losing air.

And yet somehow, the feeling of that day still lingered.

Like warmth trapped inside a blanket.

—

Kiye sat on her bed with the book resting open in her lap.

Only one chapter remained after this.

One chapter.

One final page of a story made from friendship.

—

The title stood alone at the top.

The Promise

—

Beneath it, Mimi had written:

Friendship is a strange thing.

One day you're strangers.

Then suddenly you know each other's favourite songs, favourite snacks, worst jokes, biggest fears, and the stories behind their smiles.

And you can't imagine your life without them in it.

—

Kiye smiled softly.

Because somehow that described everything.

—

She kept reading.

—

I don't know exactly what the future looks like.

None of us do.

We'll grow older.

School will end.

Life will change.

We'll meet new people.

We'll become different versions of ourselves.

—

The words felt different from the rest of the book.

Softer.

More reflective.

Like standing at the edge of something beautiful and looking back.

—

And honestly?

That scares me a little.

—

Kiye blinked.

Because Mimi rarely admitted things like that.

—

Not because change is bad.

But because I love this version of life.

This version of us.

The after-school walks.

The group chats.

The random conversations that somehow last hours.

The ordinary moments that became important without asking permission.

—

The room felt quiet.

The good kind of quiet.

—

I wish I could freeze some of these memories forever.

But that's not how life works.

—

A pause.

Then:

—

So instead, I made this book.



—

Kiye laughed softly.

Of course she did.

Of course that would be the conclusion.

—

Because even if life changes, memories stay.

Photos stay.

Stories stay.

And hopefully this book stays too.

—

The fairy lights beside her bed glowed softly.

Casting golden shadows across the pages.

—

Then she reached the next paragraph.
And immediately felt her chest tighten.

—

So here's my promise to you.

—

The words seemed bigger somehow.
More important.

—

*Years from now, I hope we're still laughing about things nobody else understands.
I hope we still send each other songs that remind us of each other.
I hope we still have inside jokes that make absolutely no sense.
I hope we still find reasons to celebrate each other's birthdays.*

—

Kiye smiled through suspiciously watery eyes.
Very suspiciously.

—

*And if life ever gets busy...
Or difficult...
Or overwhelming...*

—

She kept reading.

—

*I hope you never doubt that you mattered here.
To me.
To all of us.*

—

The sentence sat heavily in her chest.
Warmly.
Gently.
Like a hand on her shoulder.

—

*Because some people leave footprints in your life without realizing it.
And you've left them everywhere.*

—

Kiye looked down for a moment.
Unable to read.
Unable to speak.
Even though nobody was there.

—

Then she continued.

—

You helped create some of my favourite memories.

And no matter what happens next, nobody can take those away.

—

A pause.

Then one final paragraph.

—

So this is my promise:

I will always be grateful that I met you.

I will always smile when I think about these years.

And I will always be thankful that, for a little while, life gave me a friend like you.



—

Kiye stared at the page for a long time.

Long after she'd finished reading.

Long after the words had settled.

—

Because promises didn't always have to be dramatic.

Sometimes they were quiet.

Simple.

Steady.

—

Like friendship itself.

—

At the very bottom of the chapter, written in smaller handwriting, was one final note.

—

P.S.

If we're still friends when we're eighty, I'm reminding you about the hoodie theft allegations.

—

Kiye burst out laughing immediately.

Actual tears in her eyes.

—

"Unbelievable."

She shook her head.

Still smiling.

—

Somehow Mimi had managed to end one of the most emotional chapters in the entire book with a hoodie joke.

Which felt perfectly appropriate.

—

Kiye turned the page.

Slowly.

Carefully.

Because now there was only one chapter left.

One final chapter.

One final goodbye.

One final love letter to friendship.

—

And somehow she wasn't quite ready for it to end.

Chapter Forty

Fourteen 🎂💕✨

The final chapter began with a blank page.

No photos.

No playlists.

No letters.

No decorations.

Just a single sentence sitting quietly in the middle.

—

Happy Fourteenth Birthday, Kiye.

—

Simple.

Just like that.

—

Kiye smiled before turning the page.

And there it was.

The end.

Or maybe not the end.

Maybe just the beginning of a new chapter.

Not in the book.

In life.

—

The words that followed were written differently from the rest.

Softer somehow.

Like a conversation.

Like Mimi was sitting beside her.

Like she was speaking directly to her heart.

—

Fourteen.

It's a strange age.

You're not quite a little kid anymore.

But you're not grown up either.

You're standing somewhere in the middle.

Becoming.

—

Kiye read slowly.

Not wanting the pages to disappear too quickly.

—

Maybe this year will be messy.

Maybe it will be beautiful.

Maybe it will be both.

Most good years usually are.

—

A small laugh escaped her.

Because that sounded exactly like something Mimi would say.

—

You'll learn new things.

You'll make mistakes.

You'll discover new favourite songs.

You'll meet people.

You'll lose some things.

You'll find others.

You'll grow.

—

The fairy lights beside her bed glowed softly.

The room felt warm.

Safe.

Like the entire book was wrapping itself around her one last time.

—

And through all of it, I hope you remember something important.

—

Kiye already knew this part would make her emotional.

She could feel it.

—

You do not have to earn love.

You do not have to earn friendship.

You do not have to become someone different to deserve kindness.

—

Her eyes stung immediately.

Dangerous.

Very dangerous.

—

The people who love you?

They love you now.

Exactly as you are.



—

A tear slipped down her cheek.

She didn't even bother wiping it away this time.

—

The funny version of you.

The quiet version.

The confident version.

The insecure version.

The version that laughs too loudly.

The version that worries too much.

Every version.

—

The room blurred slightly.

Again.

A recurring problem throughout this book.

—

Especially the version reading this chapter right now.

—

Kiye smiled through her tears.

—

Because that girl is wonderful.



—

She stared at the page.

Reading the sentence twice.

Then three times.

Then once more.

Just because she wanted to.

—

The next paragraph was shorter.

—

Thank you for existing in my life.

Thank you for every memory.

Thank you for every laugh.

Thank you for every ordinary day that became extraordinary because you were part of it.

—

Outside, rain tapped softly against the window.

Just like it had on the night Mimi wrote so many of these chapters.

—

Then came the final section.

The very last words of the entire book.

—

One day we'll be older.

We'll look back at these years and laugh.

We'll remember things differently.

We'll forget some details.

But I hope we never forget how loved we were.

—

A pause.

Then:

—

I hope we never forget each other.



—

Kiye took a shaky breath.

The kind people take when they're trying very hard not to cry again.

And failing.

—

So here's to fourteen.

Here's to friendship.

Here's to memories.

Here's to every chapter we haven't lived yet.



—

And finally:

—

This book might be ending.

But our story isn't.

Not even close.



Love always,
Mimi

—

For a long time, Kiye simply sat there.

The book resting open on her lap.

The room quiet around her.

The final page glowing beneath fairy lights.

—

Eventually she closed the cover gently.

Carefully.

Like something precious.

—

Then she hugged the book to her chest.

And smiled.

A real smile.

The kind that comes from feeling seen.

Remembered.

Loved.

—

Because that was what this book had always been.

Not just pages.

Not just memories.

Not just a birthday gift.

—

It was proof.

Proof that she had mattered.

Proof that she had left her mark on the people around her.

Proof that friendship could be powerful enough to fill forty chapters.

—

And as Kiye looked toward the future—toward fourteen, and everything that came after it—she carried that proof with her.

Not in her hands.

Not in the book.

But in her heart.



The End

Or perhaps...

To Be Continued. 🌙

Closing Statement

And so, this book comes to an end.

Not because there are no more memories to write about, but because some stories are still being lived.

Kiye, if you've read this far, I hope you've seen yourself through the eyes of the people who love you. I hope you've seen the laughter you bring, the kindness you give, and the countless ways you've made life brighter for those around you.

This book was never really about pages, chapters, or words. It was about preserving a friendship. It was about making sure that years from now, when memories become blurry and time moves faster than we'd like, you'll still have something to hold onto.

Every chapter was written with love.

Every memory was chosen with care.

Every word was written because you matter.

Thank you for being the person who made ordinary days feel special.

Thank you for the laughs, the conversations, the inside jokes, the playlists, and the memories.

Thank you for being someone worth writing forty chapters about.

As you turn fourteen, I hope you carry this truth with you:

You are loved more than you know.

You are appreciated more than you realize.

And you have left a mark on the hearts of the people lucky enough to know you.

This may be the final page of the book, but it is not the final page of our story.

There are still memories waiting to be made.

Still songs waiting to remind us of each other.

Still birthdays to celebrate.

Still chapters left unwritten.

So here's to you, Kiye.

Here's to fourteen.

And here's to every chapter that comes next.

With all my love,

Mimi 

✨ Fin.   

For Kiye, on her 14th birthday.  

Yes — the way the story is written, Mimi and Kiye are *platonically* in love, not romantically. 

Their relationship is meant to show that deep female friendships can be intense, emotional, affectionate, clingy, beautiful, and soul-deep without being romantic or lesbian. It's that kind of friendship where:

- someone becomes your safe place,
- you care about them constantly,
- you say "I love you,"
- you fear losing them,
- and they become part of your everyday happiness.

A lot of teenage girl friendships are like that — very emotionally intimate and heartfelt — especially at fourteen when friendships can feel like entire worlds.

So the story's core is:

best friends loving each other deeply in a platonic way.

Not romance, just powerful friendship love.

Genre-

Coming-of-age • Friendship • Emotional • Wholesome • Slightly poetic